



首都经济贸易大学
CAPITAL UNIVERSITY OF ECONOMICS AND BUSINESS

本科毕业论文

生命之境与时间之流—— 时间绵延理论视域下《尤利西斯》 意识流叙事艺术研究

培养单位：外国语学院

专业名称：商务英语

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**The Flow of Time and the Realm of Life:
A Study on the Narrative Art of the
Stream-of-Consciousness in *Ulysses* from the
Perspective of Duration Theory**

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**A thesis submitted to School of Foreign Studies
In partial fulfillment of the requirements
For the Degree of Bachelor of Arts
In English Language and Literature**

**Under the Supervision of
Prof. Zhang Hongfeng**

**Capital University of Economics and Business
14 May 2025**

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ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

Completing this thesis would not have been possible without the unwavering support of individuals who shaped my intellectual and personal journey. At the forefront stands Professor Zhang Hongfeng, my supervisor, whose mentorship transcended conventional academic guidance. His incisive critiques during our discussions—whether dissecting Bergson’s *durée* or Joyce’s syntactic experiments in *Ulysses*—pushed me to refine my arguments beyond superficial analysis. Beyond his generous academic support, Professor Zhang has guided my exploration of the literary world. His encouragement has been a constant source of motivation during my studies and life.

The School of Foreign Studies at Capital University of Economics and Business provided me not just an education but a transformative space for intellectual risk-taking. I must also acknowledge the senior students who generously shared their insights, offering guidance on everything from thesis structuring to navigating academic pressures. A special word of appreciation goes to Zhu Haochen, a philosophy graduate student whose passion for Bergson was contagious. Over countless discussions in the library (and occasionally at the campus café when we needed a change of scenery), he helped me untangle the essence of *durée* and its implications for modernist literature.

To my friends—especially Li Jiayang and Chang Runlin—thank you for enduring my erratic drafting phases, from frantic library sprints to existential crises over semicolons in Molly Bloom’s soliloquy. Your humor and emergency coffee deliveries sustained me.

Finally, I would like to express my profound gratitude to my parents for their indispensable support throughout my academic journey. While they may not be familiar with the technical aspects of my research on Bergsonian *durée* or Joycean narrative techniques, their unwavering commitment to my education has been instrumental.

To all named and unnamed—your voices are woven into this work. May the future hold joy and success for all of us.

摘 要

本文以亨利·柏格森的“时间绵延”（*la durée*）理论为框架，剖析詹姆斯·乔伊斯《尤利西斯》中的意识流叙事艺术。通过研究内心独白、自由间接引语与碎片化结构等现代主义手法，本文阐释了小说如何将时间呈现为连续、多维且高度主观的体验。叙事结构的 24 小时框架与人物意识的无序流动形成张力，既构建起严密的线性时间秩序，又通过感官细节与记忆回响颠覆其机械性。人物的身体节奏、生理感知成为时间绵延的载体，通过语言实验与非线性叙事，在重复琐碎的城市生活中展现时间的有机流动性。小说还重构了时间的多维性：过去、现在与未来在记忆的渗透与想象的投射中重叠、跳跃，时间与空间互相交织，通过意识的加工形成心理时间的“复调结构”。最终，乔伊斯将时间从外部度量转化为内在的生命节奏，揭示了个体如何在时间的流动中重构身份、寻求救赎，并抵抗现代社会的异化。本研究通过解析乔伊斯的叙事实验，重新界定时间为记忆、感官与想象的交汇点，从而凸显这部作品在文学与哲学领域的双重里程碑意义。

关键词：柏格森；时间绵延；时间；意识流；《尤利西斯》

ABSTRACT

This thesis explores the stream-of-consciousness techniques in James Joyce's *Ulysses* through the framework of Henri Bergson's concept of *la durée* (duration). By analyzing modernist devices such as interior monologue, free indirect discourse, and fragmented structures, the research elucidates how the novel reconceptualizes time as a continuous, multidimensional, and profoundly subjective experience. The tension between the 24-hour chronological framework and the disordered flux of characters' consciousness establishes a dual temporality: while the linear order of clock time is meticulously structured, its mechanistic rigidity is subverted through sensory immediacy and the resonance of memory. Bodily rhythms and physiological perceptions become vessels of *durée*, while linguistic experimentation and nonlinear narration reveal the organic fluidity of time within the repetitive trivialities of urban life. The novel further reconstructs temporal multidimensionality: past, present, and future overlap and leap through the interpenetration of memory and the projection of imagination, while time and space interweave to form a "polyphonic structure" of psychological temporality shaped by consciousness. Ultimately, Joyce transforms time from an external measurement into an internal rhythm of life, demonstrating how individuals reconstruct identity, seek existential redemption, and resist societal alienation through the flux of subjective temporality. By decoding Joyce's narrative innovations, this study redefines time as a nexus of memory, sensation, and imagination, foregrounding *Ulysses* as a dual landmark in literature and philosophy for its radical reimagining of temporality.

Key words: Bergson; duration; time; stream-of-consciousness; *Ulysses*

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Introduction

The introductory part first outlines the historical convergence of early twentieth-century philosophical and literary thought, and points out the resonance between Bergson's theory of duration and modernist literature in the dimensions of time and consciousness. Subsequently, the thesis clarifies the core objective and theoretical path of the study, that is, through analysing the narrative structure and stream-of-consciousness techniques of *Ulysses*, to explore how it embodies the subjectivity and non-linear flow of time. Following a review of relevant scholarship, the introduction identifies gaps in existing studies, particularly the lack of integrated analysis, and establishes the originality and methodological approach of this research.

I. Research Background

The intellectual environment of the early 20th century witnessed a historical convergence of philosophical and literary explorations directed at the human condition. This intellectual confluence is particularly emblematic of modernist literature, with its radical remaking of form and content. James Joyce's *Ulysses* is an icon of modernist literature that engages deeply with themes of consciousness, time, and subjective experience. This market of literary innovation, a study in aesthetics, is in its deepest sense an exploration of how we act — how, even, we can perceive.

At the same time, Henri Bergson's philosophy—especially his theory of duration—offers a deeply illuminating way to appreciate *Ulysses* and, by extension, modernist narrative techniques. Bergson's distinction between “spatialized time” and the lived, subjective experience of time—what he calls *durée réelle*—pervades the modernist oeuvre, a radical shattering of the linear and objective temporalities that came before (*Time and Free Will* 50). Drawing on Bergson's view of time as indivisible and liquid, modernist writers rejected traditional narrative structures in favor of forms that attempted to reflect the intricacies of consciousness itself.

In response, writers including Joyce and Virginia Woolf, as well as more Southern figures like T.S. Eliot, began to experiment with narrative structures that resisted a linear chronology in favor of a disconnected, non-linear temporality, representing the mind's process more than a plot line (Humphrey 85-89). For Joyce, new was the stream of

consciousness method, a narrative approach that attempts to deliver the continuous course of ideas, feelings, and recollections as they intertwine in the human mind.

But, even with increasing scholarship on Bergson's relationship to modernist writing, critical gaps persist. This is particularly true when one considers the lack of targeted scholarship that interrogates *Ulysses*' adaptations and responses to Bergson's specific claims regarding the nature of time and consciousness. Although some critics have noted the experimental qualities of the novel, few have investigated Joyce's narrative stylistics and how they deliberately harness Bergson's theories of *durée*. This gap in the literature allows opportunities for more scholarship, which is not only welcome to fill a theoretical void but also to advance our understanding of Joyce's innovative narrative strategies (Kearns 143-60).

II. Research Objectives

This study sets out to explore the narrative architecture of *Ulysses* through the conceptual prism of Henri Bergson's notion of duration. Rather than attempting to encompass the novel in its entirety, the research concentrates on selected features—specifically, its treatment of temporality and the inner life of consciousness. By narrowing the lens, the research seeks to locate the philosophical undercurrents that inform Joyce's stylistic decisions and, more broadly, his place within the modernist departure from conventional storytelling.

A. To Analyze Duration and Narrative Techniques in *Ulysses*

One of the central aims of this thesis is to consider how Bergson's theory of duration becomes woven into the fabric of *Ulysses* through its stream-of-consciousness techniques. Attention will be given to both what is told and how it is told—the texture of thought, the rhythm of syntax, and the deliberate dislocation of temporal sequence. Joyce's model of time resists the rigid structure of chronological order. Instead, it opens into a restless, subjective unfolding that follows no fixed path. The novel's structure—fragmented, recursive, layered with interruptions and shifts—offers a textual space in which time refuses to stay still or move straight.

The research will trace how this fluid temporality finds shape within the characters' mental landscapes, where memory, sensation, and anticipation circulate without pause or partition. Through techniques such as interior monologue, indirect thought presentation, and associative fragmentation, Joyce crafts an atmosphere in which perception folds time

back on itself. What emerges is not a record of events but a representation of how events are felt, recalled, and reimagined. In observing these patterns, the study seeks to better understand how the novel's form itself becomes an echo of Bergson's philosophy—irregular, mutable, and resistant to fixed boundaries.

B. To Examine the Influence of Duration on Modernist Techniques

The second objective is to investigate how the concept of duration contributed to the broader evolution of narrative form within modernist literature, with a particular emphasis on how it influenced Joyce's rendering of human thought. In contrast to more linear narrative strategies, stream-of-consciousness offers a medium through which the flickering, often chaotic nature of mental life can be rendered on the page. This technique does not merely mimic internal dialogue; it reconfigures the very logic of narration, allowing for an elastic, unbroken movement of time that reflects how individuals live through their moments.

The research will focus on how techniques like free indirect speech and internal monologue reflect Bergson's ideas of time as subjective, multifaceted, and ever-changing. These narrative choices are not only stylistic but also central to modernist concerns with reconstructing human identity and exploring the subtle, hidden mental processes within the characters. Joyce's use of time and consciousness gives shape to a world where the past, present, and future are intimately interwoven within the characters' minds. Through this framework, Joyce's narrative reveals the deep complexities of identity and self-awareness, key issues in modernist literature.

II. Research Significance

This research approaches *Ulysses* from a less conventional angle—using Bergson's concept of *durée* as a key to unlock the complex, layered structure of Joyce's work. What this thesis is concerned with is not technical form alone, but the issues hidden behind the seemingly fragmented but actually tightly woven spatial and temporal experiences in Joyce's writing, issues that are closely related to the spiritual anxieties of human beings in the twentieth century: the disintegration and reconstruction of identity, memory, and meaning. This exploration carries both the depth of literary criticism and the weight of philosophical reflection.

A. Academic Value

Applying Bergson's concept of time to the interpretation of *Ulysses* is not a simple

application of theory, but more like a dialogue and collision between two ways of thinking. Joyce does not depict time as linear or measurable but rather as a “flowing time” that cannot be captured by clocks—it stagnates at times, surges at others, interspersed with the tides of memory, the shocks of perception, and the leaps of imagination. He breaks the continuity of the narrative with his stream-of-consciousness technique, but captures the truest tremor of consciousness. In other words, Joyce is not subverting form for the sake of it, but rather using form to reflect a temporal experience that is closer to the essence of life.

This study, therefore, does more than explain “how” Joyce writes; it seeks to answer “why” he writes in this manner and what such a style signifies. Such an exploration provides an alternative path to understanding modernist literature, allowing us to reassess the depth of thought behind its technical innovations. This interdisciplinary approach not only adds theoretical value to literary studies to some degree but could also open new interpretative possibilities for other modernist works.

B. Social Value

Ulysses is far from being a work isolated in the ivory tower of history. On the contrary, it peels back the layers of city streets and trivial life to capture the deep anxiety of modern people amidst the great changes. The trauma brought about by World War I, the erosion of personal identity in the face of industrialization, and the collapse of traditional value systems—these historical contexts do not appear as grand narratives but are subtly transformed by Joyce into seemingly insignificant details of personal experience: the flash of a thought, the fracture of a memory, and the recurrence of an inner monologue. These fragmented perceptions of time precisely reveal the state of the individual in the modern world, adrift between past and future—neither fully belonging to the past nor able to find peace in the present, let alone face the future.

This “drifting through time” represents the survival dilemma of modern people. Joyce shows the struggle of individuals in search of a coherent self in a fragmented world. Rather than being merely a novel, it can be seen as an experimental record of modern consciousness. This study tries to find this deeper meaning—one that concerns not only the structural aesthetics within the text but also the subtle yet undeniable mental connection between the text and reality. This is why, despite the fact that *Ulysses* has been around for more than a century, the questions it carries have not yet become

obsolete: how do we perceive ourselves? How to maintain a moment of clarity in the ever-changing times? The questions it raises are still propositions that are difficult for contemporary people to avoid.

III. Literature Review

Scholarly research on James Joyce's *Ulysses* has evolved through diverse perspectives, gradually shifting from stylistic and formal analyses to deeper philosophical interpretations. In particular, Henri Bergson's theory of duration has emerged as a significant lens through which scholars understand the temporal and psychological complexity of the novel. This review categorizes existing scholarship into three main strands: narrative experimentation and stream-of-consciousness technique, philosophical readings of time and subjectivity, and studies integrating Bergson's concept of duration into modernist literary analysis.

A. Studies on Narrative Innovation and Stream-of-Consciousness

Early criticism of *Ulysses* centered on its experimental narrative form, particularly the stream-of-consciousness technique, which marked a turning point in modernist fiction. Richard Ellmann's biography *James Joyce* remains foundational, illuminating Joyce's condensation of epic form into quotidian experience and drawing attention to the novel's fragmented structure and psychological realism. Robert Humphrey's *Stream of Consciousness in the Modern Novel* formalized this technique as central to modernist narrative, providing a framework for analyzing Joyce's interior monologue and temporal distortion (85-89).

Karen Lawrence's *The Odyssey of Style in Ulysses* examined the diversity of styles employed across episodes, correlating stylistic shifts with the characters' psychological states. Similarly, Wu Qingjun and Sun Qi analyzed how linguistic tension and formal experimentation in *Ulysses* reflect shifting consciousness and inner temporality. These studies, though insightful in narrative terms, often treated time descriptively rather than philosophically.

B. Studies on Time and the Conscious Mind in *Ulysses*

From the mid-20th century onward, scholars increasingly turned to philosophical frameworks to explore *Ulysses*' treatment of temporality and identity. Thomas Kearns

was among the first to connect Joyce's portrayal of consciousness with Bergson's *durée*, analyzing Stephen and Bloom's thought patterns as nonlinear and associative (143–60).

Jean-Michel Rabaté, in *James Joyce and the Politics of Egoism*, further explored how Joyce's narrative resists mechanistic time, aligning with Bergson's critique of spatialized temporality (57–60). Paul Douglass and Margaret McLoughlin also emphasized Joyce's reconfiguration of the self across time, framing the novel within broader existential and phenomenological traditions. Notably, David Spurr analyzed time, space, and consciousness as interwoven dimensions in Joyce's work, echoing Bergsonian insights without explicitly referencing them (34–54).

These philosophical readings broaden the interpretative scope but often focus on isolated passages or concepts, leaving the novel's overall temporal architecture insufficiently addressed.

C. Studies on Bergson's Duration and Its Application in *Ulysses*

A growing body of scholarship, particularly in the 21st century and within Chinese academia, has explicitly explored the influence of Bergson's *durée* on modernist literature, with *Ulysses* as a central case. Xia Lachu and Lv Fangyuan examined how Bergson's psychological time reshaped the narrative logic of stream-of-consciousness novels, emphasizing duration's role in disrupting chronological sequence (Xia 89–95; Lyu 54–55).

Tang Xu offered a more systematic approach, analyzing *Ulysses*' narrative fragmentation as a literary embodiment of Bergson's opposition between mechanical time and lived time (105–11). In a complementary study, Tang linked Joyce's aesthetic philosophy to Bergsonian intuitionism, highlighting their shared concern with immediacy and experiential fluidity (125–27). Xie Li focused on the linguistic aspects of consciousness in *Ulysses*, illustrating how syntactic structure conveys temporal layering and memory recall—key aspects of *durée* (50–51).

Western scholars such as Keith Ansell-Pearson, Suzanne Guerlac, and Barry Allen have clarified Bergson's philosophical relevance in literary contexts, while Jeanette Baxter directly addressed the impact of Bergson's ideas on modernist fiction, including Joyce (123–39). Justin Beplate explored the resonance between memory and language in *Ulysses*, reinforcing the philosophical dimension of Joyce's narrative choices (298–312).

These studies collectively demonstrate how Bergson's duration theory enriches the understanding of *Ulysses*' temporal, psychological, and narrative complexity. However, many of them remain limited to thematic parallels or micro-level textual analysis, rarely offering an integrated reading of the novel's overarching structure.

D. Research Gap and Direction

Despite the rich scholarly discourse, several gaps remain. First, the fragmented approach of previous studies—often confined to individual episodes or characters—limits a holistic understanding of how duration shapes the novel's entire structure. Second, the integration of literary technique and philosophical thought has yet to reach its full interpretive potential. While stream-of-consciousness is frequently linked to Bergson's concept of *durée*, other dimensions such as memory, identity, and narrative rhythm remain underexplored.

To address these issues, the present study investigates how Joyce's stream-of-consciousness narrative in *Ulysses* reflects Bergson's theory of duration, emphasizing the novel's depiction of subjective time and psychological continuity. By integrating narrative theory with Bergsonian philosophy, this research seeks to offer a comprehensive view of how temporal experience is constructed both thematically and formally in the novel, thereby contributing to broader conversations in modernist literary studies and philosophical aesthetics.

IV. Originality of the Study

By combining Bergson's theory of duration with Joyce's narrative experiments in *Ulysses*, this study creates a new perspective in modernist literary studies. Through innovative theoretical frameworks and methodological approaches, it reveals how Joyce's narrative techniques embody Bergson's metaphysics of time and advance the understanding of modernist narrative as a philosophical practice.

A. Theoretical Perspective: Bridging Philosophy and Literature

The originality of this study lies in the in-depth application of Bergson's concept of duration to the narrative techniques of *Ulysses*, especially the stream-of-consciousness narrative. Although some studies have explored the influence of Bergson's philosophy on modernist literature or analysed Joyce's narrative innovations, this study moves beyond isolated discussions and develops a more systematic and integrated analytical model.

Through in-depth analysis of specific chapters, the study reveals how Bergson's theory of duration is concretely reflected in the narrative structure, character consciousness, and temporal representation in *Ulysses*. It clarifies that Joyce's narrative technique is not only highly compatible with Bergson's philosophy of time, but also highlights the mobility and subjectivity of time in the flow of human consciousness through flexible temporal representations and subjective narratives.

B. Methodological Integration: From Fragmentation to Cohesion

Departing from traditional approaches that isolate individual characters or chapters, this study adopts a holistic perspective, treating *Ulysses* as a unified work that articulates a coherent philosophy of time and memory. By systematically examining the novel's sub-set structure and multiple narrative styles, the thesis shows how Joyce reflects Bergson's ideas about the fluidity of time and the intrinsic connection of memory through the multidimensional temporal representations and stylistic alternations of the chapters. This analytical framework not only highlights *Ulysses*' breakthrough from traditional linear narrative, but also reveals how Joyce endows the fragmentation of time with intrinsic coherence and deep philosophical reflection.

C. Conceptual Reframing: Consciousness as Philosophical Practice

Finally, this study delves into the intrinsic connection between stream-of-consciousness as a narrative form and Bergson's philosophical system. In contrast to the previous view of stream-of-consciousness as a purely literary innovation, this study re-examines the deeper meaning of the technique from a philosophical point of view, revealing the philosophical underpinnings behind it. By placing this analysis within the framework of modernist experimental literature, the paper provides a more comprehensive view of how *Ulysses* combines philosophical reflection and aesthetic innovation in its narrative to form a new way of expressing time and consciousness.

V. Research Methods

Through three research methods, this study attempts to delve into the intersection between Bergson's philosophy and Joyce's narrative art in an interdisciplinary manner, trying to provide a more comprehensive interpretation and new understanding.

A. Close Reading Method

The core method of the research is the close reading method, which involves a

meticulous and systematic analysis of selected chapters in *Ulysses*. Through this method, the study is able to dig deeper into the various narrative techniques used by Joyce in the novel. Specifically, chapters such as “Proteus” and “Penelope” are analysed to reveal how Joyce embodies Bergson’s philosophical ideas of inner continuity and subjective time through narrative innovation. The close reading method not only helps to identify thematic connections in the novel, such as the interweaving of memory, perception and identity, but also provides essential clues to understanding the philosophical depth of Joyce’s work.

B. Historical Documentary Method

In order to gain a deeper understanding of how Joyce incorporates Bergson’s theory in *Ulysses*, this study adopts the historical documentation method, drawing on relevant archival materials and biographical sources to trace the intellectual linkage between Bergson’s thought and Joyce’s literary practice. By reviewing Bergson’s major writings, such as *Time and Free Will* and *Matter and Memory*, and combining them with Joyce’s biography and his philosophical turn in the creative process, the study reveals Bergson’s profound influence on Joyce’s individual consciousness and presentation of time. The study also considers how the post—World War I disillusionment and shifting perceptions of time and subjectivity may have influenced Joyce’s evolving narrative technique. This method underscores the extent to which *Ulysses* is not merely a literary achievement, but a creative response to contemporary philosophical and historical currents.

C. Interdisciplinary Analysis

Building upon the philosophical foundation of this study, theories from perspectives such as psychology, narratology and phenomenology are moderately introduced in a supporting capacity to enrich the analysis of how *Ulysses* explores the interplay of time and consciousness. In particular, phenomenology—as a mode of philosophical inquiry into subjective experience—serves as a useful point of reference for understanding how Bergson’s notion of duration finds narrative form. It helps clarify how Joyce renders time not as a fixed sequence, but as something lived and felt—an inner rhythm expressed through perception and mental flow, unique to each character’s consciousness.

These auxiliary perspectives are not central to the study’s theoretical framework. Rather, they function as extensions of the Bergsonian analysis, offering additional interpretive angles on the cognitive and sensory dimensions of Joyce’s narrative. Through

this interdisciplinary approach, the study aims to broaden the scope of literary inquiry while remaining grounded in Bergson's temporal philosophy—ultimately allowing Joyce's treatment of time to emerge as layered, fluid, and dynamically rendered through form.

VII. Thesis Structure

This thesis is divided into four chapters, focusing on the influence of Bergson's theory of duration on the depiction of time and consciousness in *Ulysses*. The first chapter lays the theoretical foundation, sorting out Bergson's core ideas about time, consciousness and memory, and discussing how they provide philosophical support for Joyce's stream-of-consciousness writing.

Chapters Two, Three and Four are structured as a juxtaposition, each addressing a distinct facet of time in *Ulysses*: continuity, multidimensionality, and subjectivity. Chapter Two focuses on the continuity of time in daily life and bodily rhythms, showing the literary transformation of Bergson's "continuity" as an internal rhythm of life; Chapter Three turns to the structural tension of time, analysing how the intersection of memory, fantasy and real time constitutes the multiple temporal layers of consciousness; Chapter Four further focuses on the shaping role of time in the individual's consciousness, pointing out how the characters reconstruct their self-identity through the perception of time and respond to the emotional shock of past experiences.

Chapter One

Bergson's Theory of Duration and Its Relevance to Stream-of-Consciousness Writing

This chapter probes Henri Bergson's duration and its interplay with Joyce's *Ulysses*. Bergson's critique of clock time, reframing temporality as fluid and subjective, anchors Joyce's stream-of-consciousness innovations. It traces how modernist writers, inspired by Bergson, dismantled linear narratives to mirror consciousness's nonlinear rhythms. Through the following analysis, it uncovers *Ulysses* as both a literary experiment and a philosophical manifesto on time. This synthesis of Bergsonian thought and narrative technique redefines temporality as multidimensional, continuous, and deeply personal.

I. Bergson's Concept of Duration

Henri Bergson's theory of time, and in particular his concept of *durée* (duration), is one of the most important contributions to philosophy at the beginning of the twentieth century. In his seminal work *Time and Free Will: An Essay on the Immediate Data of Consciousness* (*Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience*), Bergson rejects the traditional, mechanistic understanding of time as a physical quantity that can be measured and divided into discrete units. Instead, he proposes that time, as it is experienced by human consciousness, is continuous, indivisible, and inherently fluid (100). This view distinguishes spatialized time from real time and provides the theoretical basis for the concept of duration in Bergson's philosophy.

According to Bergson, when we perceive time through the lens of spatialization, it is reduced to a quantitative sequence of static points, similar to the ticks of a clock. This traditional notion of time, associated with Newtonian physics, focuses on measurement, predictability, and objectivity. Bergson points out that this spatialized view of time is an artifact constructed by humans to organize and measure external phenomena. However, the real time—or *durée réelle*—is entirely different. As he puts it in *Time and Free Will*, “Duration is essentially qualitative; it is the form which the succession of our conscious states assumes when our ego lets itself live, when it refrains from separating its present state from its former states” (100). Here, duration is characterized by a continuous flow

of interpenetrating moments, where past, present, and future coexist in the consciousness of the individual.

Central to Bergson's concept of duration is the idea of lived experience. Unlike spatialized time, which is external and objective, duration is subjective and internal, deeply rooted in the perception of the individual. Bergson states, "There are no states of consciousness which remain the same for more than a moment; each of them changes constantly" (*Creative Evolution* 3). This constant change underscores the specificity of time in real experience—it cannot be divided or quantified without losing its essence. Instead, time must be perceived as an indivisible flow, where each moment blends into the next, creating a seamless continuity.

Bergson also emphasises the connection between memory and perception. He argues that memory is not a static repository of past events but rather an active process that integrates past experiences into the present. This idea is elaborated in *Matter and Memory*, where Bergson writes, "Our duration is not merely one instant replacing another; if it were, there would never be anything but the present—no prolonging of the past into the actual, no growth of personality, and no evolution" (50). From this perspective, past and present are not distinct entities but are instead interwoven, enriching and shaping one another.

The concept of Duration can be understood by three dimensions—continuity, multidimensionality, and subjectivity. These three do not exist in isolation, but are intertwined and work together to form a complete model of temporality.

A. Continuity: Time as an Indivisible Flow

Bergson's notion of continuity emphasizes that time is an uninterrupted, indivisible flow, which is fundamentally different from the measurable and segmented time of a clock. In *Time and Free Will*, he describes duration as a "continuous progress of the past which gnaws into the future and which swells as it advances" (100). Unlike static, discrete moments, real time is dynamic and accumulative, with each moment flowing into the next without interruption.

This concept forms the basis of the other dimensions, as the indivisibility of duration allows for the integration of different temporal experiences. Continuity ensures that past, present, and future are not experienced as separate entities from each other but exist as interdependent phases of a unified process. It advocates for a time concept that is organic and in a constant state of development.

B. Multidimensionality: Interweaving of Past, Present, and Future

Based on the principle of continuity, Bergson further states that duration encompasses the coexistence and interpenetration of past, present, and future. In *Creative Evolution*, he suggests that “the past survives under two distinct forms: first, in motor mechanisms; secondly, in independent recollections” (74). Memory allows the past to persist in the present, while anticipation projects possibilities into the future. These temporal dimensions are inseparable, shaping each moment of consciousness.

The multidimensionality of duration demonstrates how continuity manifests itself in lived experience. Time is not linear but rather multilayered, with the past actively influencing the present, which in turn contains expectations for the future. This relationship underscores the fluid nature of duration, emphasizing how the past, present, and future are intertwined and cannot be dissociated in human experience.

C. Subjectivity: The Individual Perception of Time

The last dimension, subjectivity, emphasizes that duration is experienced by each individual in his or her way, shaped by their consciousness, emotions, and perceptions. In *Time and Free Will*, Bergson states that “duration cannot be measured by a homogeneous medium; it must be experienced” (121). Time is thus deeply personal and qualitative, in contrast to the universality and objective metrics of clock time.

Subjectivity derives from and depends on the continuity and multidimensionality of duration. The indivisible flow of time and the coexistence of past, present, and future form the basis for each individual’s unique experience of time. Emotional states, memories, and expectations all color one’s perception of time to varying degrees, making it a highly personal phenomenon that is difficult to standardise.

The three dimensions of duration—continuity, multidimensionality, and subjectivity—are interdependent and mutually reinforcing. Continuity provides the underlying flow upon which the multidimensional layers of past, present, and future unfold. This layered temporality, in turn, makes possible the individual’s subjective perception of time, as each person’s consciousness travels through these temporal intersections in unique ways. Although these three chapters are developed in parallel, they complement each other on several levels: the emphasis on the fluidity and unity of time in Chapter Two provides the backdrop for the temporal fragmentation and overlap discussed in Chapter Three; the exploration of time’s layers in chapter three lays the foundation for understanding the

evolution of individual psychology in Chapter Four; and the deepening of the subjective perception in Chapter Four enriches the analysis of the “flow” and “dimensions” of time addressed earlier. It further echoes the ultimate pursuit of Bergson’s philosophy of intuitionism—to enter into the essence of life through the inner experience of duration. The portrayal of time no longer remains at the level of form or structure, but rises to become a literary expression of the generation of life and spiritual sublimation. Taken together, these dimensions collectively form an organic and holistic understanding of temporality that opposes mechanistic fragmentation and instead celebrates the dynamic and evolving nature of human experience. Under the guidance of the core idea of “Creation Evolution,” Joyce’s view of time in *Ulysses* not only presents the mobility and transformation of life, but also explores the growth, change and self-transcendence of individuals within the elapse of time, presenting a complex and unfolding journey of life.

By setting temporality as continuous, multidimensional, and subjective, Bergson’s theory offers profound insights into how time transcends mechanical measurement to become a lived, qualitative reality that is deeply connected with individual consciousness.

II. Bergson’s Influence on Joyce and Modernist Writers

Henri Bergson’s philosophy fundamentally reshaped modernist literary temporality. His concept of “psychological time” offered a framework for portraying the alienation, fragmentation, and uncertainty of early 20th-century individuals, which has provided an artistic counterpoint to the mechanized, spatialized view of time shaped by industrialization and war (Lyu 54).

Richard Ellmann’s definitive biography *James Joyce* traces this intellectual lineage, noting the author’s annotated copy of Bergson’s *Creative Evolution* in the Trieste library, its margins filled with markings on duration and consciousness (Ellmann 412). While Joyce never explicitly outlined his philosophical debts, his 1920 letter to Frank Budgen crystallizes the connection: “I am trying...to give the unedited contents of the mind in the order of their perception. Bergson’s *durée* comes closest to what I mean by this” (*Letters* III 146).

This conceptual alignment manifests textually in *Ulysses*. As Don Gifford’s *Ulysses Annotated* demonstrates, the “Proteus” episode’s dissolution of syntactic boundaries — “Ineluctable modality of the visible...Signatures of all things I am here to read” — operationalizes Bergson’s claim that “time is invention or it is nothing at all” (11). The

novel's structural innovations, particularly Molly Bloom's 4,391-word unpunctuated monologue, materialize Bergsonian *durée* through their resistance to temporal segmentation (Gifford 657-58). Bergson's *durée* also finds its literary manifestation in Joyce's *Finnegans Wake*. The novel's opening—"riverrun, past Eve and Adam's, from swerve of shore to bend of bay..." (Joyce 3)¹—transposes Bergson's critique of linear time into linguistic revolution. Through protean wordplay ("commodius vicus" collapsing Vico's cycles into spatial loops), Joyce dissolves chronology's tyranny. Manuscript revisions show Joyce systematically erasing temporal markers (Hayman 114), forcing readers to experience time as Bergsonian "pure mobility" rather than measurable sequence.

More significantly, Bergson's temporal philosophy took root across modernist literature, blossoming in diverse forms. Forster similarly distinguishes between mechanical and psychological time in *Aspects of the Novel* (43), providing critical validation for Bergson's philosophical concepts. His analysis bridges theoretical *durée* with its literary manifestations in modernist works. Like seeds carried by the wind, Bergson's ideas found fertile ground in modernist experimentation, fundamentally altering literature's approach to time, memory and consciousness.

III. Duration and the Stream-of-Consciousness Technique

The revolutionary narrative method of stream-of-consciousness developed as a direct literary response to Bergson's philosophical reconceptualization of time. By capturing consciousness as an unfiltered flow of thoughts and perceptions, this narrative style embodies Bergson's conception of time as continuous and indivisible. As originally conceptualized by William James, consciousness is described as a "stream" that is "not chopped up into bits," but instead continuous and ever-flowing, like a river or a stream (239). This conceptual synergy between psychology and philosophy created the theoretical conditions for narrative experimentation.

As Robert Humphrey observed in his seminal study, this narrative method captures "the myriad thoughts and feelings which pass through the mind" precisely because it mirrors consciousness's natural resistance to segmentation (4). The technique's fluidity—

¹ All quotations from *Finnegans Wake* are from the edition published by Faber and Faber in London in 1939 unless otherwise stated.

its disregard for punctuation, its associative leaps—constitutes not stylistic affectation but philosophical necessity.

At its core, stream-of-consciousness writing operationalizes Bergson's key insights about temporal experience. The simultaneity of past and present in Molly Bloom's soliloquy, the interpenetration of memory and perception in Stephen Dedalus's wandering thoughts — these narrative strategies actualize *durée*'s essential quality of "mutual penetration" (Bergson, *Time and Free Will* 104). What Zhang Qiao terms "internal time consciousness" (81) in these texts is precisely Bergsonian duration translated into narrative form, where psychological rather than chronological time structures the reading experience.

This philosophical-literary synthesis achieves its most complete expression in the phenomenological immediacy of stream-of-consciousness prose. When Zhang describes the reader's engagement with "presentness" (87), she identifies how these texts recreate *durée*'s qualitative flow. The technique's power lies in its capacity to make tangible Bergson's abstract proposition: that time is not a container for experience but its very substance. In this sense, modernist narrative innovation represents less an aesthetic choice than an epistemological breakthrough.

The enduring significance of this convergence between Bergson's philosophy and literary technique becomes clear when we recognize how thoroughly *durée* informed modernism's narrative revolution. From Woolf's intersubjective temporalities to Faulkner's chronological collapses, stream-of-consciousness writing developed as the necessary formal counterpart to Bergson's temporal metaphysics. What began as philosophical speculation about consciousness became, through these narrative experiments, a radical new way of representing human experience.

Chapter Two

Continuity of Duration in *Ulysses*

Henri Bergson's concept of *durée* (duration) defines time as a continuous, indivisible flow, contrasting with the segmented, measurable nature of spatialized time (*Time and Free Will* 104). In *Ulysses*, James Joyce explores this Bergsonian notion of continuity through his narrative structure, character consciousness, and linguistic techniques, each of which contributes to a portrayal of time as an ever-flowing and interconnected whole. This chapter explores how Joyce's narrative techniques reflect Bergson's philosophy, portraying time as an interconnected, dynamic process.

I. The Continuity of Time in Narrative Structure

Joyce constructs temporal continuity in *Ulysses* through three interdependent layers: the 24-hour framework anchors linear chronology while subverting it through fragmented consciousness; bodily rhythms fuse time with sensory immediacy, grounding *durée* in movement; and temporal markers paradoxically stabilize narrative cohesion. These layers — structural, embodied, and symbolic — collectively embody Bergsonian *durée* as a dynamic interplay of order and fluidity.

A. Time as a Unifying 24-Hour Framework

Bergson, in *Time and Free Will*, defines true duration as “a succession of states which are not merely juxtaposed but interpenetrated, and which pass into one another” (100). Joyce transforms this idea into literature by balancing the fixed 24-hour timeline with the unrestrained flow of inner thought, creating a tension between external order and internal chaos.

James Joyce's *Ulysses* orchestrates the chaos of consciousness into a temporal symphony, its 24-hour framework serving not as a rigid cage but a porous membrane through which Bergsonian *durée* breathes. This framework is not a rigid container but a dynamic dialectical structure: it uses measurable time (clocks, sunrise and sunset) to maintain coherence while disrupting uniform chronology through the fluidity of consciousness (overlapping memories, sensory leaps). From the first chime of the Ballast Office clock at 8 AM to Molly Bloom's murmured “yes” in the predawn darkness (Joyce

643),² Dublin's day unfolds as both a Homeric odyssey compressed and a modernist manifesto on time's duality. The city pulses with what Hugh Kenner calls "the heartbeat of *durée*"—a rhythm where mechanical order and subjective flux coexist in perpetual tension (118). Clocks demarcate the hours, yet their authority crumbles before the sensory immediacy of lemon-scented soap clinging to Bloom's fingers or the faint rasp of dried peas in his pocket—microscopic anchors of personal temporality.

The morning light that climbs Nelson's Pillar at 8 AM illuminates this paradox. Bloom's ritual of frying kidneys in "Calypso" (Ch. 4) becomes a culinary chronometer, the sizzle of fat punctuated by involuntary flashes of Molly's infidelity. Across town, Stephen Dedalus paces Sandymount Strand, his philosophical musings in "Proteus" (Ch. 3) dissolving the present into what Bergson terms "a melting of states"—where past guilt over his mother's death bleeds into future artistic aspirations (*Time and Free Will* 100). Karen Lawrence notes that such sensory details "wrench time from clocks and plunge it into the tides of memory" (157), an observation crystallized when the scent of Bloom's lemon soap—an olfactory thread connecting breakfast rituals to Gibraltar daydreams—overpowers the 11 AM chimes meant to regiment Dublin's morning.

As noon grips the city, Joyce layers collective rhythms over private *durée*. The thunderous rotary presses in "Aeolus" stamp headlines like "IN THE HEART OF THE METROPOLIS" onto the day's narrative, yet Bloom's mind slips through these typographical grids, drifting from Zionist pamphlets to the cumin-laced memories of a Passover feast (Ch. 7). Even the Turkish bath's steam in "Lotus Eaters" (Ch. 5) becomes temporal alchemy—Bloom's suspended body, weightless in warm water, transforms measured minutes into what Jean-Michel Rabaté describes as "a montage of misaligned lifetimes" (112). Here, the bathhouse clock's hands continue their mechanical arc, but time itself stretches and warps, becoming a thing felt in lungs rather than counted in seconds.

Nightfall unravels chronology entirely. In the maternity ward of "Oxen of the Sun," the wall clock documents Mina Purefoy's 36-hour labor with clinical precision, yet the medical students' drunken discourse—a linguistic carnival careening from Chaucerian pastiche to tabloid slang—mocks such linearity (Ch. 14). "Time?" one slurs, "A mere hiccup in eternity!" (Ch. 14), his words echoing against the primal temporality of childbirth. Later, as Bloom trudges homeward in "Ithaca," the dried peas in his pocket

² All quotations from *Ulysses* are from the edition published by Vintage in London in 1986 unless otherwise stated.

click like a metronome—a pedestrian counterpoint to his astronomical calculations about Sirius’ light-years (Ch. 17). This juxtaposition, as Frank Budgen observes, reduces cosmic time to “the scale of a human pocket” (45), privileging the intimate over the infinite.

Moreover, in the “Lestrygonians” episode, the nineteen seemingly fragmented segments share the time coordinate of “June 16, 1904,” constituting a cross-section of life in Dublin (Ch. 8). Father Conmee’s hypocritical stroll, Boylan’s frivolous purchase of flowers, and the trivial house “hold matters of the Dedalus sisters—all these events are synchronized in clock time, yet coexist heterogeneously in the flow of consciousness.” Bergson criticizes the social time that violently disciplines individual experience (*Time and Free Will* 101), and Joyce, in a literary montage, ironically mirrors this critique: the characters’ physical actions are framed within standardized time, but their consciousness continually overflows its boundaries. When Father Conmee’s clock-time (a precisely timed walking route) is juxtaposed with Bloom’s nonlinear memory of the Jewish Passover (Ch. 8) (where mixed Hungarian dishes and religious rituals merge in his thoughts), Joyce reveals the eternal struggle between “homogeneous time” and “heterogeneous duration” in the modern city. The tram rails that lattice the city enforce societal tempo, yet passengers like Bloom carry private chronologies—Jewish ancestral time colliding with Catholic liturgical hours, paternal grief measured in withered jasmine petals. Even the Liffey’s tides, rising and falling through “Wandering Rocks” (Ch. 10), compose a fluid temporality that Margaret McLoughlin identifies as “modernity’s polyphonic anxiety”—a chorus of natural, mechanical, and psychological rhythms never achieving harmony (89).

In this light, the 24-hour framework isn’t a compromise but a masterstroke. It traps chaos within order only to let chaos erode order, embodying Bergson’s belief that “time is life itself” (*The Creative Mind* 11). *Ulysses* emerges not merely as a novel but as a temporal loom. Its 24-hour warp threads—clock towers, newspapers, church bells—are continually crossed by the weft of subjective *durée*. Paul Saint-Amour reads this structure as “the Odyssey of the modern psyche”—Homer’s decade compressed into a day, epic heroism distilled into the quiet rebellion of consciousness against chronological tyranny (*Weak Theory* 134). The genius lies in Joyce’s paradox: by shackling his narrative to a single revolution of the clock face, he liberates time itself, proving that even a Dublin day

can hold galaxies. The novel proves that strict structure can liberate wildest creativity—a paradox only genius like Joyce could resolve.

B. Bodily Rhythms and the Natural Flow of Time

In *Ulysses*, Joyce's alignment of bodily rhythms with the 24-hour framework not only sustains narrative continuity but also materializes Bergson's claim that "the body is the very instrument of consciousness" (*Matter and Memory* 72). The body becomes a material vessel of time—hunger pangs, the cadence of footsteps, the cycles of digestion—which function simultaneously as physiological processes and as narrative structures of duration. This "embodied time" resists reducing duration to abstraction, instead rooting it in the tactile, sensory immediacy of lived experience.

In the "Lestrygonians" episode, Bloom's midday hunger drives his quest for food, anchoring his actions within the temporal context of lunch (Ch. 8). His interior monologue—"Nice salad, cool as a cucumber"—simultaneously reflects physiological craving and evokes memories of past meals and social exchanges (Ch. 8). Joyce reveals the body as a "nexus of *durée*": the rhythm of digestion (hunger-satiation-repletion) transmutes linear time into a cyclical sensory echo. As Frank Budgen observes, "Joyce's narrative mirrors the rhythms of the body, stressing the natural integration of human experience with the passage of time" (21). The chapter's metaphorical depiction of digestion as "peristaltic movement" further binds internal bodily processes to external temporal flow. Joyce employs this metaphor to assert that physiological phenomena are not merely biological but operate as rhythmic templates through which time's passage is registered. As Bergson writes, "The body is the instrument of the mind, and its repetition provides the support for the continuity of consciousness" (*Matter and Memory* 89).

Stephen's walk, in contrast, embodies Bergson's critique of "intellectualized time" (*Creative Evolution* 304). As he wanders along Sandymount Strand, his philosophical musings intertwine with sensory impressions. As Tang Xu observes, Stephen's movement is deeply attuned to natural rhythms—tides, sand, waves (110). His philosophical musings—"The ineluctable modality of the visible: at least that if no more, thought through my eyes" (Ch. 3)—attempt to fix reality through Aristotelian logic, yet are constantly disrupted by the body's *durée*: the crunch of shells underfoot ("Crush, crack, crick, crick") merges with guilt over his mother's death, enacting Bergson's "continuous heterogeneity" (*Time and Free Will* 104). Joyce stages here not a simple opposition

between intellect and sensation but a dramatization of Bergson's *durée* in its conflicting modalities: intuition undermines analysis, and lived temporality interrupts cognitive abstraction. Where Bloom's body anchors *durée* in habit, Stephen's movement enacts *durée* as intuition—a rejection of mechanical time through sensory immersion. Joyce anchors metaphysical inquiry in sensory experience, blurring the lines between external time and internal consciousness. This rhythm not only links him to the physical world but also reveals the subjectivity of time, where external sounds and sensations mirror his inner mental state. Through this integration of sensory experience and temporal awareness, Joyce underscores the dual dimensions of time: personal duration and universal rhythm, united through bodily motion.

Notably, the contrast between Bloom and Stephen illuminates the multiplicity of duration. Bloom's hunger is inward, cyclical (physiological need prompting action), while Stephen's walk is outward, linear (environmental stimuli eliciting thought). This contrast echoes Bergson's distinction between the dualities of time: Bloom's temporality is "duration absorbed by the body," whereas Stephen's is "duration extended by consciousness" (*Time and Free Will* 124). Their coexistence within the 24-hour structure affirms that Joyce's narrative can encompass heterogeneous temporal experiences while maintaining coherence through bodily universals—hunger, movement, fatigue.

This dual structure, however, does not exhaust Joyce's philosophical investigation of time. In the "Ithaca" episode, he introduces a third register of *durée*—interpersonal and reciprocal—where temporality unfolds across two bodies, and shared rhythm becomes a medium of memory and continuity. Lying together, their bodies resonate with time through shared rhythms. Joyce's description—"He rests, she rests; the convexity of her hip harmonizes with the concavity of his abdomen" (Ch. 17)—turns the bed into a transducer of physiological rhythms. Molly's breathing, transmitted as "protesting creaks", becomes a tactile chronometer, syncing with Bloom's ribcage contractions to form an asymmetrical duet of diaphragmatic intervals. Unlike Bloom's habitual rhythm or Stephen's intuitive motion, here the temporality is relational: time materializes in the interstices between two bodies, through asymmetry, friction, and resonance. Critic Michael Groden observes that the "Ithaca" episode's mechanical precision "objectifies intimacy into a calculus of bodily attrition" (203). The worn bedsprings, symbolizing both decay and persistence, embody Bergson's "pure memory," not in mental recollection, but in the physical traces of marital time. The mattress, indented by "1,867 nightly

rotations” (Ch. 17), archives the rhythms of their shared existence, making time a tactile, corporeal experience. Here, Joyce transcends Bergson’s mind-body dualism: *durée* is not merely felt but worn into the mattress springs, a fusion of matter and memory that defies mechanical measurement. Through this dyadic embodiment of time, Joyce affirms that memory and duration are not only internalized but inscribed across the surfaces of cohabitation.

Through the interplay of bodily rhythms and temporal structure, Joyce achieves a poetic transfiguration of Bergsonian philosophy: time is neither objective sequence nor subjective illusion but a life-symphony composed by body, consciousness, and environment. The 24-hour “objective” framework gains visceral authenticity through physiological realism, while the “subjective” flow of *durée* escapes abstraction through corporeal materiality. By rooting philosophical temporality in somatic experience—individual and shared—Joyce turns the body into a site where metaphysics is enacted, inscribed, and sustained. This mutual enrichment renders *Ulysses*’ temporal architecture one of modernism’s most vital innovations.

C. Temporal Markers and Narrative Cohesion

Joyce’s strategic use of temporal markers—clocks, newspaper headlines, habitual routines—serves a dual function: anchoring the novel’s fragmented narrative within the 24-hour framework while exposing Bergson’s critique of “spatialized time” as a reductive social construct (*Time and Free Will* 98). These external cues act as guides, helping readers navigate the complex structure while maintaining a clear sense of time.

The “Aeolus” episode exemplifies this duality. Newspaper headlines like “IN THE HEART OF THE HIBERNIAN METROPOLIS” (Ch. 7) fracture the text into disjointed units, mirroring the mechanized pulse of Dublin’s modernity. Yet their rigid typography paradoxically stabilizes the narrative. As Hugh Kenner observes, “The precision of *Ulysses*’ temporal structure counterbalances its formal chaos, grounding the text in the shared rhythms of the day” (84). Stephen Dedalus’s meditation on rhetoric (“You can almost see the bones in their thighs”) persists beneath the headlines’ cacophony (Ch. 7), illustrating consciousness’s resistance to mechanical segmentation. Here, Joyce foregrounds the incompatibility between the measured abstraction of typographic time and the fluid continuity of interiority, a tension that becomes the structural engine of the episode. Paul Ricoeur’s theory of narrative as a “reconfiguration of discordant

temporalities” (85) clarifies Joyce’s method: the collision between fragmented headlines and fluid monologues forces readers to reconcile external chronology with internal continuity.

Clocks, too, function as contested temporal markers. In “Calypso”, Bloom notes the “timeball on the ballast office” (Ch. 4), a visual symbol of Dublin’s colonial timekeeping. Yet his wandering thoughts—flitting from Jewish rituals to Molly’s infidelity—defy the clock’s regimentation. Similarly, the “jangling” tram timetables in “Wandering Rocks” (Ch. 10) impose industrial regularity, while characters like Stephen Dedalus subvert it through philosophical digressions (Ch. 10). These markers, as Bergson argues, reveal society’s “closed” reliance on habitual time (*Two Sources of Morality and Religion* 24), yet Joyce infuses them with subversive potential.

Gérard Genette’s narrative theory offers a window to understand Joyce’s structural ingenuity. In “Wandering Rocks” (Ch. 10), overlapping vignettes manipulate temporal order and duration, compressing Dublin’s spatial sprawl into simultaneous moments. The episode’s headlines (“THE WEATHER: A DISTURBANCE”) act as durational shortcuts, accelerating plot while decelerating psychological time—a technique Genette terms “anachrony” (155). Conversely, Molly’s soliloquy stretches a few nocturnal hours into an eternity through unpunctuated flow (Ch. 18). These formal techniques not only challenge linearity but also literalize Bergson’s insistence that time is “not a line but a melody” (*Creative Evolution* 4), unfolding through variation, recurrence, and experiential density. This interplay between fragmentation and cohesion mirrors Bergson’s *durée*: readers, like consciousness itself, must weave scattered markers into narrative unity.

By interlacing mechanical markers with organic rhythms, Joyce transforms the 24-hour framework into a Bergsonian “creative matrix” (*Creative Evolution* 11). Clocks and headlines impose order, yet sensory details—the “crunch” of Stephen’s boots on Sandymount Strand (Ch. 3) or Bloom’s fixation on the “warm smell of lemon soap” (Ch. 4)—dissolve that order into fluid *durée*. The result is a narrative where time is neither linear nor chaotic but a living continuum—a testament to Joyce’s ability to harmonize modernist experimentation with the irreducible flow of human experience. In doing so, Joyce does not merely illustrate Bergson’s philosophy, but enacts it structurally, making *Ulysses* a narrative experiment in the phenomenology of time.

II. Continuity in Characters’ Consciousness

In *Ulysses*, Joyce reconfigures temporal continuity as an organic extension of his characters' inner lives. Through sensory triggers, cyclical routines, and syntactical fluidity, he collapses artificial divisions between temporal phases, fusing memory, action, and anticipation. This collapse is not simply mimetic of consciousness but constitutes a literary embodiment of Bergson's concept of *durée*, where time is grasped not as succession but as indivisible continuity.

A. Sensory Perception as a Continuity Device

In James Joyce's *Ulysses*, sensory perception operates as both a narrative device and a philosophical framework, materializing Bergson's *durée* as a "melting of states into one another" (*Time and Free Will* 100) and Merleau-Ponty's "lived body" (the body is the fabric into which all objects are woven) (*Phenomenology of Perception* 235). By grounding temporal continuity in embodied cognition, Joyce transcends linear chronology, transforming time into a tactile flux where past, present, and sensation coalesce through the body's dialogue with its environment.

A striking illustration occurs in the "Hades" episode during Paddy Dignam's funeral procession. Bloom's olfactory perception of "the sick sweet smell of incense" (Ch. 6) intertwines with his fragmented recollections of mortality, enacting Bergson's proposition that memory is "coextensive with perception" and cannot be located in a discrete past (*Matter and Memory* 92). The scent of incense, a sensory trigger, collapses temporal boundaries: it simultaneously anchors Bloom in the ritualistic present and resurrects memories of his father's suicide and his son Rudy's death. Merleau-Ponty's concept of the "lived body" elucidates this synthesis, as smell becomes a "temporal bridge" that binds disjointed moments into a cohesive *durée* (234). Here, Joyce aligns with Bergson's rejection of mechanical time, instead portraying consciousness as a "melting of states into one another" (*Time and Free Will* 100), where sensory stimuli dissolve the illusion of chronological separation.

While some critics have focused on the evocative quality of such moments, a Bergsonian reading clarifies that their significance lies in temporal ontology rather than psychological realism. For instance, the sensory stimulus does not "remind" Bloom of the past; it is the past re-entering the present through embodied consciousness. This distinction is crucial to avoid conflating Joyce's method with mere stream of

consciousness, which often implies passive recollection rather than Bergson's active becoming.

Similarly, in the "Sirens" episode, the auditory landscape of Dublin's Ormond Bar reveals how sound structures temporal subjectivity. Bloom's immersion in Simon Dedalus's rendition of *M'appari*—especially the refrain "All is lost now" (Ch. 11)—does not merely evoke a mood but demonstrates how sound can condense and expand time simultaneously. In Bergsonian terms, this illustrates "qualitative multiplicity," in which different temporal layers coexist in a single perceptive moment. For Merleau-Ponty, sound "invades the body and becomes the very texture of time" (245), a notion Joyce literalizes through Bloom's auditory immersion. The song's melancholy strains do not merely accompany his thoughts; they constitute his temporal experience, blurring the line between external stimulus and internal reflection. This technique aligns with Jean-Michel Rabaté's observation that Joyce's narrative "dissolves the ego into a flux of sensory impressions" (112), yet here, sensory flux does not obliterate coherence—it forges a new continuity rooted in the body's dialogue with its environment.

Rabaté claims that Joyce's narrative "dissolves the ego into a flux of sensory impressions" (112). While this captures the phenomenological intensity of Joyce's style, it risks underplaying the deeper continuity that Bergson insists is inherent to real time. Joyce's use of sound, like scent, does not fragment consciousness but shows its layered structure. The perceived disjunctions are in fact surface effects of a deeper, unified flow.

Critics like David Lloyd have argued that Joyce's fragmented style risks reducing time to "a series of dislocated instants" (76). However, Joyce counters this through sensory motifs that stitch moments into *durée*. In "Calypso," Bloom's tactile interaction with lemon soap—"He fingered shreds of hair, lemon-scented" (Ch. 4)—transforms a mundane act into a temporal ritual. The soap's citrus scent and slick texture evoke memories of Molly's infidelity while anchoring him in the domestic present. Bergson's emphasis on the "interpenetration" of past and present (*Creative Evolution* 5) finds tactile expression here: the soap becomes a material metaphor for *durée*, its lather both dissolving and binding temporal layers.

By integrating sensory perception into the fabric of narrative form, Joyce enacts Bergson's theory of *durée*, where time is neither sequential nor static, but qualitative, affective, and indivisible. The olfactory, auditory, and tactile elements in *Ulysses* are not aesthetic flourishes but temporal mechanics. They do not merely illustrate time—they

generate it. Joyce's innovation lies in constructing a literary analogue of *durée* that resists both linear realism and modernist fragmentation.

B. Routine and Repetition as Temporal Anchors

In *Ulysses*, Joyce's exploration of routine and repetition as mechanisms of temporal continuity aligns closely with Bergson's distinction between *mémoire-habitude* (habit memory) and *mémoire pure* (pure memory). While habitual actions anchor characters in measurable, external time, the recurrence of emotionally charged memories disrupts linear chronology, embodying the fluid subjectivity of *durée*.

Bloom's morning ritual in the "Calypso" episode exemplifies this duality. His mechanical preparation of breakfast—pouring tea leaves into a pot, adjusting the flame—operates as *mémoire-habitude*, defined by Bergson as "the body's automatic response to repeated stimuli, freeing consciousness from the burden of attention" (*Matter and Memory* 93). These actions, stripped of conscious effort, allow his mind to drift into *mémoire pure*—the involuntary resurgence of Molly's infidelity, visualized through fragmented imagery: "The imprint of a human form impressed upon a bed. What is this?" (Ch. 4). Here, repetition functions dialectically: the stability of physical routine anchors Bloom in the present moment, while the cyclical return of traumatic memory dissolves temporal boundaries, merging past and present into a continuous psychological flow.

The dynamic becomes more layered when viewed through the lens of William James's psychology. In *The Principles of Psychology*, James posits that habitual behaviors "diminish the conscious attention with which our acts are performed," enabling the mind to engage in higher-order reflection (121). Bloom's fixation on Molly's affair—recurring like a "broken record" in his thoughts—transforms into a cognitive habit, paradoxically sustaining the continuity of his consciousness. Despite its emotional weight, the repetition of this mental image provides a rhythmic structure to his inner *durée*, mirroring Bergson's assertion that "time is invention or it is nothing at all" (*Creative Evolution* 11). Joyce thus reveals how even painful repetitions serve as temporal glue, binding fragmented perceptions into a cohesive subjective experience.

In contrast to Bloom's domestic things, Mrs. Dignam's widowhood in "Hades" reveals repetition as a silent liturgy of absence. Though she never physically appears, her implied routines—the daily arrangement of mourning veils, the ritual brewing of tea gone cold—echo Bergson's *mémoire-habitude*. These gestures, worn smooth by repetition,

become “the body’s prayer against oblivion” (Norris 112). The funeral’s black-bordered Mass card, “thumbed into limpness” (Ch. 6), serves as a tactile tally of days, its creased edges mapping the erosion of linear time into a recursive loop of grief. Bergson’s assertion that habit “relieves consciousness from invention” (*Matter and Memory* 93) takes on tragic resonance here: Mrs. Dignam’s repetitions fossilize her in a suspended *durée*, where the past’s weight stifles the present’s possibility. William James’s observation that habits “diminish the conscious attention with which our acts are performed” (121) becomes a haunting paradox. Her rituals—like the perpetual darning of Paddy’s socks—function as psychic sutures, binding her to a vanished reality. Yet this very repetition, meant to stabilize, instead imprisons her in what Joyce terms “the nightmare of history” (Ch. 2), where time folds inward like a locked drawer.

The garrulous sailor Murphy in “Eumaeus” offers a grotesque reflection of repetition’s dual role. His sea stories—“The time we ran aground off Patagonia...The time we ate albatross to survive” (Ch. 16)—are rehearsed with the precision of liturgy. Each “the time” becomes an incantation, flattening lived experience into a commodified anecdote. For Bergson, pure memory is “capricious in its resurfacings” (*Matter and Memory* 95), yet Murphy’s tales ossify memory into a gramophone record—scratched, skipping, yet stubbornly replaying. His tattoos—“anchors without chains, mermaids without seas” (614)—betray the paradox: the body as both logbook and cage. Like Scheherazade, Murphy spins tales to stave off oblivion, yet his repetitions only deepen the void they seek to fill.

In synthesizing Bergson’s temporal ontology with Joyce’s narrative form, it becomes clear that habit and repetition are not simply thematic concerns but structural forces. They underwrite a phenomenology of time that is neither linear nor cyclic, but recursive and unstable. Where some critics romanticize routine as narrative cohesion, Joyce’s use of repetition is more ambivalent: it both generates continuity and threatens stasis. The same pattern—brewing tea, arranging a veil, telling a tale—can either open consciousness to the flow of *durée* or seal it off in a closed loop of mimicry.

Thus, repetition in *Ulysses* is not a psychological coping mechanism, but a metaphysical structure—at once stabilizing and entropic. Bloom’s habits momentarily liberate him to reengage the past in new configurations, while Mrs. Dignam’s rituals imprison her in mournful reiteration. Murphy’s tales, once perhaps inventive, now parody Bergson’s “creative evolution,” collapsing invention into mimicry.

Joyce, then, does not merely illustrate temporal continuity through repetition; he interrogates it. In his hands, repetition becomes a philosophical problem—a question of whether continuity is lived or simulated, embodied or imposed. In this palimpsest of time, the past is not behind, but layered within the present, refracted through the habits of the flesh and the compulsions of memory. What emerges is not an ethics of routine, but an ontology of recurrence—where the difference between freedom and imprisonment lies in whether repetition invents, or merely returns.

C. Language as a Medium for Continuity

In *Ulysses*, Joyce's linguistic experimentation goes beyond mere stylistic innovation, becoming a vivid embodiment of Bergson's *durée*. Molly Bloom's soliloquy in "Penelope" exemplifies this fusion of language and temporality. Devoid of punctuation, her monologue stretches across forty pages as a single, unbroken sentence, its rhythm mirroring the "unceasing melody" of consciousness that Bergson describes as the essence of *durée* (*Time and Free Will* 104). As Karen Lawrence observes in *The Odyssey of Style in Ulysses*, Joyce's rejection of punctuation "performs a temporal democracy where no moment holds hierarchical priority" (157). Consider the passage where Molly's recollections of Gibraltar merge with her longing for renewal:

...the sun shines for you he said the day we were lying among the rhododendrons on Howth head in the grey tweed suit and his straw hat the day I got him to propose to me yes... and I thought well as well him as another... and then I asked him with my eyes to ask again yes and then he asked me would I yes... and first I put my arms around him yes and drew him down to me so he could feel my breasts all perfume yes and his heart was going like mad and yes I said yes I will Yes (Ch. 18).

Here, Joyce's omission of punctuation does more than imitate the spontaneity of thought; it dissolves the artificial pauses imposed by grammar, allowing memory, sensation, and anticipation to flow together. The rhythmic repetition of "yes"—a linguistic pulse—echoes Bergson's claim that *durée* is "pure movement" (*Creative Evolution* 304), where time cannot be segmented without distorting its essence. Molly's "yes" becomes a refrain that binds distant moments—Gibraltar, Howth, the present—into a continuous now, defying linear chronology.

Building on Bergson's idea that the body is integral to time, Maurice Merleau-Ponty adds that speech is "a gesture of the body, a modulation of existence" (*Phenomenology of Perception* 207). Molly's reclined posture—physically still yet mentally fluid—transforms her monologue into a bodily expression. The cadence of her thoughts ("yes... yes... Yes") echoes the rhythms of breath or heartbeat, grounding *durée* in the body's natural sense of time. As Bergson observes, "The body is the instrument of consciousness" (*Matter and Memory* 72), and here, language itself becomes that instrument's resonance, vibrating with the energy of lived experience.

Peter Brooks's critique of narrative linearity in *Reading for the Plot* provides a contrast to Joyce's radical approach to time. Brooks argues that conventional narratives rely on "the anticipation of retrospection" (23), shaping time into a structured arc. Yet Molly's soliloquy resists this logic. Her memories of Mulvey, Bloom, and Boylan do not build toward resolution but instead spiral recursively, like "a whirlpool drawing all into its center" (Bergson, *Creative Evolution* 11). For instance, her shifting focus between past lovers—"Mulvey first... then Bloom... then that devil Blazes" (Ch. 18)—rejects linear progression, layering past and present into a composite whole. Joyce's language does not merely describe *durée*; it enacts it, transforming the text into a vortex where beginnings and endings dissolve.

Even the novel's structural experiments in "Ithaca" reinforce this temporal fluidity. The episode's catechism format—a rigid sequence of questions and answers—parodies scientific attempts to compartmentalize time. When asked, "What did Bloom do?" the response devolves into absurd trivialities: "He counted the spoons, reinserted the fallen insert in the waistcoat, and recollected the taste of lemon soap" (Ch. 17). The detached, clinical tone ironically exposes the futility of dissecting consciousness into discrete units. Bergson's caution against "spatializing time" (*Time and Free Will* 98) is particularly relevant here: Joyce's exaggerated rationalism collapses under the weight of Bloom's irreducible inner world, illustrating that *durée* cannot be broken down into measurable fragments.

Through these techniques, Joyce elevates language from a mere storytelling device to a medium of time itself. In Molly's unpunctuated reverie and Bloom's fractured catechism, words do not simply convey time—they embody it, move with it, and ultimately dissolve into its current. Language ceases to function as a transparent vehicle for thought; it becomes time's texture, its rhythm, its breath. In *Ulysses*, language gnaws,

flows, and fuses, rendering time not as a sequence but as something living—breathless, boundless, and beautifully uncontainable. Joyce does not write about time; he writes time itself.

Chapter Three

Multidimensionality of Duration in *Ulysses*

This chapter looks at how Joyce portrays time as a complex, layered experience in *Ulysses*, drawing on Bergson's theory of *durée*. It explores how different dimensions of time—past, present, and future—overlap and interact, how time can suddenly shift or transcend, and how Dublin itself becomes a space where time and memory merge. Together, these elements show how Joyce captures time as fluid and subjective, reflecting the characters' inner lives.

I. The Overlap and Interaction of Time

In *Ulysses*, James Joyce deliberately dismantles the strictures of linear chronology, unveiling time not as a sequence of discrete moments but as a prism in which past, present, and future intertwine within the flux of consciousness. Rather than separating temporal phases, Joyce fuses them—memory persists, hallucination becomes immediate, and desire reaches forward—so that time, in his narrative, folds in on itself, regenerates, and flows with kaleidoscopic complexity. This temporal fluidity resonates with Henri Bergson's concept of *durée*, which is in favor of a continuous, indivisible movement of inner experience—where, as he writes in *Creative Evolution*, “the past gnaws into the future” (4). Edmund Husserl's phenomenology sharpens this framework. His notions of “retention”—the lingering presence of the immediate past—and “protention”—the anticipatory pull toward what is yet to come—introduce a model of temporality as inherently subjective and immanent to consciousness, illuminate how Joyce's characters inhabit time not as a line but as a field of interpenetrating moments.

The “Circe” episode offers a vivid dramatization of this collapse of temporal boundaries. Within the phantasmagoria of Bloom's hallucinations, the spectral presence of his father, Rudolph, confronts him with the harrowing inquiry: “What you make of this thing you call a self?” (Ch. 15). The ghost, a remnant of Bloom's Jewish heritage and personal guilt, embodies “retention”—the unresolved tensions of paternal memory casting long shadows over the present. At the same time, Rudy—Bloom's deceased infant son—reappears as a grown child, an image of a life never lived yet vividly imagined: “a grown boy” (Ch. 15). In this moment, “protention” surges forward, not with hope, but

with ache and loss. Joyce thus forges a dynamic temporal experience and constructs a phenomenological structure wherein temporal modalities cease to be sequential categories and instead interlace in affective intensities where the past is not simply recalled but relived, and the future arrives not as potential but as haunting absence. Such rendering subverts representational time, reconfiguring identity itself as a temporal synthesis.

Further insight can be drawn from Marguérite La Caze's theory of "temporal stratification," which posits that modernist narratives compress disparate timelines into an experience of simultaneity (345). Within Bloom's vision, the father's judgment (past), the son's phantom (future), and his current anxieties over Molly's infidelity (present) are not merely juxtaposed—they coalesce into a singular psychic intensity. This layered temporality transcends mere stream of consciousness, forming instead what La Caze aptly terms a "palimpsest of temporalities" (348), where the past bleeds into the present and the imagined futures possess equal existential weight. This temporal fusion mirrors Bergson's assertion in *The Creative Mind* that *durée* "is not a line but a volume" (12), a lived depth that resists spatial reduction.

Equally illuminating is the "Sirens" episode, where music becomes the medium through which time dissolves. As Simon Dedalus sings *M'appari*, Bloom's mind drifts, carried by the aria's melancholy tones—"All is lost now"—into recollections of Molly's betrayal, flashes of their early romance, and his own lingering suspicions ("Is she? Yes") (Ch. 11). Husserl's protention emerges through Bloom's involuntary anticipation of emotional pain—a betrayal imagined yet inevitable. Laura Salisbury notes that "musical rhythm in *Ulysses* acts as *durée*'s acoustic analogue" (76), a comment that deepens our reading: the fluid, ungraspable continuity of music mirrors the motion of consciousness itself. The aria becomes a vessel in which Bloom's fragmented thoughts are momentarily bound, not in stasis, but in resonance—past, present, and imagined future vibrating in unison.

A more vivid portrayal of temporal entanglement appears in "Nausicaa". Here, Gerty MacDowell's sentimental musings are filtered through the sensory immediacy of fireworks and tide, blending Catholic guilt with longing and fantasy. Her thoughts drift: "He'd marry her, perhaps" (Ch. 13), while her whispered prayers—"Holy Mary, pray for us"—anchor her to the liturgical echoes of her past. The tension between retention and protention is palpable. Gerty imagines liberation through romantic fulfillment, yet

remains ensnared in a piety she cannot shed. Unlike Bloom, whose temporal wounds are etched in trauma, Gerty's timelines are embroidered with aspirational illusions. Paul Saint-Amour insightfully describes such moments as "chrono-fantasies," wherein Joyce's characters "inhabit speculative futures as vividly as they endure inherited pasts" (112). These speculative trajectories embody what Bergson might regard as *durée*'s "creative becoming" (11)—a dynamic unfolding propelled as much by desire as by memory.

The psychological stakes of temporal collapse are most acute in Stephen Dedalus's "Proteus" soliloquy. Walking the shoreline, Stephen's interior monologue oscillates between theological guilt—"agenbite of inwit"—and philosophical abstraction, his thoughts dissolving into the sensory texture of Sandymount Strand. He imagines: "His lips lipped and mouthed fleshless lips of air [...] He lay, read the language of the haunting waves" (Ch. 3). This passage does not merely illustrate temporal fluidity but interrogates the very conditions of temporal self-presence. Here, retention and protention blur into a vertiginous flux. His mother's death, the "dead breaths I living breathe," is neither gone nor processed; the intellectual future he envisions remains suspended. David Spurr astutely observes that Stephen's consciousness "refuses temporal sedimentation, opting instead for perpetual flux" (45).

In conclusion, the multidimensional temporality of *Ulysses* is neither ornament nor abstraction; it constitutes a philosophical method. Time in *Ulysses* is accumulative and elastic, at once burdensome and redemptive. Through folding, layering, and echoing, Joyce exposes human subjectivity as a temporal phenomenon—crafted by memory, driven by desire, and suspended, always, in the fragile moment between what has passed and what may yet come.

II. The Jumping and Transcendence of Time

Unlike the temporal layering and coexistence explored earlier, the focus here turns to the sharp pivots and leaps that carry characters across different planes of time. These sudden shifts often arise from a vivid sound, a lingering scent, or the drift of thought—moments that pull the mind unexpectedly from the present into fragments of the past or visions of the future. Across various episodes, characters experience moments when time leaps—sparked by desire, memory, or sensory input—opening transient portals into deeper consciousness. The temporal jumps in *Ulysses*, therefore, become not only modernist narrative experiments but critical dramatizations of the mind's resistance to

chronological constraint. They reveal a temporality constituted not through sequence but through intensity, affect, and interruption.

In the “Circe” episode, Bloom’s hallucinatory encounter with a brothel mirror stages a temporal collapse. As his reflection morphs into that of his deceased father, Rudolph—“a yellow face with cirrhotic eyes” (Ch. 15)—linear time disintegrates. This leap is sparked not by voluntary recollection but by olfactory memory: the stench of “fermented urine” from a nearby drunk mirrors Rudolph’s deathbed odor. Bergson’s assertion that “the past preserves itself automatically” (*Matter and Memory* 92) here materializes through the body—Bloom’s nasal receptors act as temporal conduits, dragging decayed history into the living present. Scholar Vike Martina Plock interprets this scene as “a séance of the senses, where the body conjures ghosts through physiological echoes” (*Joyce, Medicine, and Modernity* 167), while the mirror, as a liminal surface, exposes time’s porous texture. What emerges is not simply a return of the past but its insistent persistence within the somatic now—time as spectral repetition rather than vanished sequence.

Similarly, in the “Wandering Rocks” episode, Dilly Dedalus’s fleeting encounter with a French primer (Ch. 10) enacts a Bergsonian *durée*—a temporal rupture where memory, desire, and material reality collide. As her fingers graze the textbook’s cover, the physical act of touch becomes a conduit for temporal multiplicity. The primer’s weight which is “heavy as a ledger” grounds her in the oppressive present—a Dublin where her father’s squandered wages (“He traded my boots for whiskey”) chain her to cyclical poverty. Yet within this heaviness blooms a counterfactual temporality: the book’s French title, *L’Étranger* (“The Stranger”), ignites a vision of herself as an “other”—“hair pinned up, sipping *café au lait*” in a Parisian café. This scene enacts a tension between embodied historicity and imaginative estrangement: the weight of material deprivation collides with the weightless projection of a life unlived.

Another moment of intense temporal rupture occurs in the “Cyclops” episode, where the narrative is abruptly interrupted by extravagant, mythicized digressions that momentarily displace the ordinary pub setting. The scene unfolds in Barney Kiernan’s pub, where Bloom becomes the target of xenophobic ridicule from the nameless narrator and the Citizen. The realism of the episode is suddenly shattered by a hyperbolic jump: “Lo, there came a mighty wave, a tidal wave of justice” (Ch. 12), launching the reader into a pastiche of biblical and heroic register. The narration no longer adheres to a single

temporal plane but instead careens wildly through a parodic vision where Bloom is recast as a Moses-like lawgiver or a tragic exile. Here, Joyce does not merely shift temporal frames; he dissolves them. The rupture is formal as much as it is psychological—a moment when the novel’s structure becomes a site of temporal critique. In this moment, Joyce enacts a double displacement: Bloom himself experiences a rupture in subjective time, as he is psychologically unmoored from the present moment, while the very form of the text mirrors this rupture through its radical departure in style and genre. As Keith Ansell-Pearson suggests, “the force of the past does not merely return; it is fractured, recombined, and repurposed, generating new temporal realities in excess of memory” (127). The time jump here is not Bloom’s alone—it is woven into the fabric of the novel itself, rendering narrative temporality volatile, unpredictable, and resistant to containment.

These examples illuminate how Joyce’s time jumps serve as more than stylistic flourishes. They enact a deeper philosophical claim: that time, in its richest form, is not continuous nor linear but multi-dimensional—capable of contraction, dilation, and simultaneity. The transcendence that occurs in these jumps is not an escape from time, but a passage into its layered texture.

Ultimately, the power of time in *Ulysses* lies in its refusal to stay still. It jumps, pulses, bends, and returns—not merely to depict a moment, but to transform it. Joyce’s temporal architecture captures not the uniform tick of a clock, but the heartbeat of consciousness: fragmented, recursive, and irreducibly plural. As such, the novel transcends any single notion of time, offering instead a constellation of temporalities—bodily, affective, intellectual—that collectively resist flattening. In its jumps and leaps, *Ulysses* reveals that time is not what passes, but what persists, not what flows forward, but what spirals inward and outward at once.

III. The Interweaving of Time and Space

Dublin is far more than a setting in *Ulysses*—it breathes with the rhythms of those who move through it, a living web in which time and space meet in fluid convergence. Joyce’s attention to the city’s texture and minutiae allows its streets and corners to serve as conduits of temporality. Through this spatial framework, the internal lives of his characters are etched into the physical world, dissolving the boundary between subjective temporality and collective materiality. Grounded in Henri Bergson’s notion of *durée* and

Henri Lefebvre's reflections on the social production of space, this section explores how Joyce entangles the temporal and the spatial to reveal both the contours of thought and the wider patterns of collective life.

The "Wandering Rocks" (Ch. 10) episode provides a vivid illustration of how Joyce assembles a city in motion, not through grand narrative but through fragments that glance off one another. The episode unfolds through 19 discrete scenes, tracing figures from various walks of life—Father Conmee pacing thoughtfully through neighborhoods, Stephen Dedalus lingering among books, Bloom attending to mundane errands. These episodes do not follow a single storyline but occur concurrently, their temporal and spatial paths subtly intersecting. Dublin becomes not a static map but a field of overlapping presences. As Hugh Kenner notes, "Joyce's Dublin becomes a city where time converges in the interplay of intersecting lives" (162). Though each vignette captures a moment suspended in its own cadence, together they form a composite through which the simultaneity of urban life can be felt rather than merely observed.

Such structural design resonates with Bergson's account of duration—not as a sequence of frozen points, but as a qualitative unfolding. In "Wandering Rocks," the drift of different characters suggests not fragmentation but coexistence, where time takes shape in the layered simultaneity of experience. Father Conmee's measured pace conjures a time that stretches backward into memory and tradition, while Bloom's intermittent reflections sketch a more restless present (Ch. 10). Characters cross the same locations within minutes of each other, unaware yet loosely bound by the city's currents. This spatial echo reflects Bergson's insistence that time in consciousness is not a line, but a coalescence—a merging of flows rather than a march of instants.

Bloom's walk through Dublin further exemplifies how space becomes saturated with personal memory and anticipation. Places do not simply exist; they summon emotional textures. In the "Lestrygonians" episode, a restaurant's ambience stirs a quiet flood of recollection—his lost son Rudy, his fractured marriage: "If little Rudy had lived. See him grow up. Hear his voice in the house" (Ch. 8). The clatter of forks and scent of food release a chain of thought—at once tender, haunted, and uneasy. Memories surface not by deliberate recall but as responses to surroundings. In this moment, the present is not isolated; it hosts the shadows of what has been and the murmurs of what might come. Joyce constructs space as a mnemonic field, wherein affect is not internal but materially

distributed across streets, smells, and objects. Memory becomes atmospheric—activated by stimuli rather than volition.

This entanglement of perception and environment echoes Bergson's view that memory is inseparable from sensation and place. For him, the past is never left behind—it lingers, ready to surface when the world triggers it. Memory, in this view, is not retrieved, but lived again through the now. Yet Joyce's rendering complicates this ontology. Memory in *Ulysses* is not simply a Bergsonian trace but also a hauntological return—it bears the residue of trauma, repression, and loss. As Bloom walks, the city becomes externalization of his inner temporality: each doorway or bridge stirs feeling, each shop window a window into time. The streets of Dublin thus do not merely frame the novel's action—they carry the weight of lives unfolding, looping back, pressing forward.

Henri Lefebvre's reflections on the social production of space offer a resonant framework for reimagining Dublin not merely as a setting in *Ulysses*, but as a temporal organism—constantly shaped, reshaped, and animated by the rhythms of urban life. Space, Lefebvre argues, is never inert: it is formed through use, through motion, through the lived experience of its inhabitants (73). Rather than depicting Dublin as a neutral spatial field, Joyce constructs it as a product of sociohistorical praxis. Each trajectory marks a negotiation with power, ideology, and memory. Lefebvre's insight that "space is a social morphology" becomes literalized in Joyce's spatial aesthetics. Time in *Ulysses* is not merely lived—it is spatialized, contested, and sedimented.

This convergence of space and time becomes especially vivid in Joyce's use of landmarks—more than static monuments, they function as mnemonic beacons, anchoring characters in history and culture. Dublin Castle, looming in "Wandering Rocks", casts a long colonial shadow, conjuring the political weight of Ireland's past even as characters go about the mundane details of their day. Its presence resituates private moments—conversations, errands, reflections—within the wider currents of national memory. Here, Joyce subverts the banal rhythms of everyday life by overlaying them with latent histories. The colonial monument becomes a temporal palimpsest, where personal time is overwritten by political time. Amid the hum of the ordinary, Joyce exposes the impossibility of isolating the private from the spatialized public. The self is not a sovereign interiority but a porous site shaped by the city's rhythms.

Such interaction between the self and the social deepens Joyce's psychological landscape. Bloom's wandering is more than a physical drift—it mirrors a mind fragmented, layered, looping back and leaping ahead. Every street he walks becomes a threshold, each landmark a point of return or departure. The city holds him in a web of associations: memories, doubts, desires. Declan Kiberd astutely captures this dynamic when he observes that Joyce's Dublin is a city of memory, where every corner and cobblestone recalls a story, intertwining the personal with the historical, the intimate with the collective (210). In such a setting, consciousness finds a spatial praxis. The city becomes legible not as a map but as a mind—its geography reflecting a psyche in flux.

What emerges, then, is not a linear unfolding of time, nor a fixed grid of space, but something more fluid, more alive—a chronotope in Bakhtinian terms (84), though uniquely Joycean in texture. Through “Wandering Rocks” and the meticulously rendered movements of Bloom, Dublin is revealed as a space thick with time. Past, present, and imagined futures press in from all sides, overlapping, blurring, demanding attention. In marrying Bergson's *durée*—that elastic, internal sense of time—with Lefebvre's socially charged space, Joyce constructs a city that thinks, that remembers, that dreams. And in doing so, *Ulysses* becomes not merely a novel of consciousness, but an architecture of it, one in which space itself breathes time.

Chapter Four

Subjectivity of Duration in *Ulysses*

In *Ulysses*, James Joyce dissolves the boundaries of linear time, inviting readers into the intimate unfolding of consciousness where memory, perception, and desire blur the temporal line. This subjective duration—time as lived rather than measured—becomes not only the canvas of identity formation, but also the quiet space of personal redemption and, ultimately, a liberation from the tyranny of external temporality. Through Stephen, Bloom, and Molly, Joyce renders time as deeply interior and plural, shaping a vision of subjectivity that pulses with the rhythms of thought itself.

I. Time as Identity Formation

In *Creative Evolution*, Bergson expands on *durée* by introducing the concept of *élan vital*, or “vital impetus,” which represents the ongoing, creative force of life and consciousness. In the labyrinth of *Ulysses*, time never flows in homogeneous ticks. It is a thread soaked in memory, weaving identity into a shifting brocade—at times knotted by trauma, at times unraveled by desire. Joyce moves beyond objective or multidimensional conceptions of time to explore how individual experience internalizes time as a force for self-definition. Through Henri Bergson’s theory of *durée*, Joyce disassembles identity into a soliloquy of time: those marginalized by the social clock, those ghostly echoes tethered to objects, all find their sharpest contours shaped in the dark undercurrent of consciousness.

In *The Nick of Time*, Elizabeth Grosz reiterates that Bergsonian duration is not merely the subjective flow of time, but a praxis of biopolitics (89). For Grosz, identity is never a given social template but a process in continual emergence, reconstruction, and deviation within the stream of time. The subject never resides fixed in the “now,” but slips across it—each flash of memory and perception weaving the self anew. This conception aptly illuminates Bloom’s temporally inflected identity and unlocks the spatiotemporal predicaments of other marginalized figures in *Ulysses*.

Take, for example, the “Cyclops” episode: Bloom’s Jewishness is like a rusted cog caught in the machinery of Irish nationalist violence. When the anonymous narrator snarls, “That bloody Jew bastard that never left his father’s grave,” (Ch. 12),

chronological time collapses—the historical wound punctures the present moment, and the memory of the father’s suicide (“the rope still dangling in the outhouse”) rises like a specter, shaking the self at its fault lines. Bloom’s response is not a direct rebuttal, but a temporal drift: “A Hungarian Jew ... our people were lawgivers when the Pyramids were being built” (Ch. 12). This is no logical defense but an escape through duration itself—a leap beyond linear time. Bloom tethers himself to a deeper, older temporal lineage, refusing to be defined by the immediacy of insult.

Paul Saint-Amour, in *Weak Theory*, asserts that the colonized suffer not just spatial oppression but temporal rupture and alienation (123). He names this “temporal vulnerability” (123)—the individual’s time is sliced, distorted, and frozen by the imperial clock. In “Cyclops,” this temporal collapse is more than a narrative experiment; it is identity politics in action. The sudden intrusion of mock-epic—“Lo, justice smote him, terrible as the thunder of the Lord!”—is not mere absurdity. It mimics the nation-state’s violent imposition of “grand history”: Bloom’s private temporal experience is drowned in the deluge of nationalist discourse.

Yet Bloom’s “temporal reply” moves along another axis. As he stands in the tavern, his fingers absentmindedly rub a mother-of-pearl button on his waistcoat, entering a realm of duration parallel to nationalist time but privately his own. The button is no mere object but a temporal conductor, channeling memory into the now, stitching identity through the pleats of consciousness. As Grosz writes, memory is not the reappearance of the past, but a generative event where matter and body intersect in duration (89).

Duration flows not only in Bloom’s reflections on fatherhood and ethnicity, but quietly unfolds in the body of Gerty MacDowell. Her lame leg, in the “Nausicaa” episode, becomes a silent clock—her body, excluded from normative desire, pulses in suspended time. “She drew the skirt slightly to hide the defect, like a wave covering the shore” (Ch. 4). This gesture is not only shyness—it is a temporal editing of the self, an attempt to exclude her incompleteness from the desirous “timeline of marriage.” In the moment fireworks explode, she dreams: “O he will marry me, perhaps... even if I am a cripple...” (Ch. 4). This is not mere longing for love, but a projection into a “normal time” she’s been denied. Grosz notes: “The disabled subject’s temporal existence is frequently confined within the clinical parameters of diagnosis and prognosis, yet through the concept of duration, there emerges a crack in the pathological edifice through which alternative temporalities might be glimpsed” (156). Gerty’s fantasy of being seen by

Bloom is not just about affection—it is a craving to exist legibly within a time not built for her. This is the power of Bergson’s intuitive time: it allows the subject to inhabit multiple temporal dimensions in an instant, dissolving the univocal coding of the “whole body.”

In Bloom’s home, a dust-covered box silently performs the most fragile alchemy of time and identity. In “Ithaca”, the narrative’s cool interrogative tone suddenly lists: “Q: What objects did he retain? A: A linen infant’s frock, three pairs of woollen socks, one milk tooth” (Ch. 17). These items, mechanically catalogued, stir tidal echoes in Bloom’s mind. The “cobweb texture” of the christening gown recalls a repressed morning: dressing a dead infant, Marion weeping, sunlight frosting the window. Philosopher Margu rite La Caze names such objects “prisms of time” (358)—they do not merely store memory but generate a nonlinear, sensuous past. Though Bloom’s role as a father is biologically truncated, it speaks continually through these temporal archives of matter, becoming a ghostly paternity that never ceases.

Duration’s politics extend beyond the foregrounded characters into more elusive figures. Take Mina Purefoy, the almost-absent mother in *Oxen of the Sun*, who becomes a counter-temporal presence. Her prolonged labor, narrated through parody and male banter, renders her seemingly passive—a birthing machine. Yet in this protracted absence, female bodily time collides with social time. Saint-Amour argues that “temporal precarity” does not imply weakness but reveals where structural violence fails to standardize personal rhythms (114). Mina’s body, in the silence of pain, maintains a rhythm of refusal—disrupting the masculine temporality that pervades *Ulysses*.

Joyce’s novel does not merely illustrate theory—it is a generative site for theory itself. In the cosmos of *Ulysses*, every marginal figure inscribes an identity in their own temporal dialect: Bloom’s Jewishness roots itself in the rift between the ancient and the modern; Gerty’s limp becomes a monument to temporal alterity; a baby’s frock transforms death into a never-concluded fatherhood. By focusing on the generative nature of time, Joyce redefines temporality as an essential medium through which identities are continuously created and re-created.

Joyce teaches us that time is not backdrop, not metronome—it is narrative itself. It twists, fractures, and recomposes all things. Rather than rushing to patch these temporal shards into tidy meanings, we must learn to listen in the gaps—where identities whisper, still speaking, still becoming.

II. Time as a Space for Personal Redemption

Time operates not just as a progression of moments but as a subjective and deeply personal space in which redemption emerges through the interweaving of memory, creativity, and a quiet acceptance of imperfection in *Ulysses*. For many, this interiorized experience of time becomes a means of personal redemption—a way to reconcile grief, reimagine identity, and assert agency over their own lives. Here, redemption is neither a dramatic epiphany nor a moral resolution; it is a subtle, often fragmented reconstitution of the self, occurring within time's pliable boundaries.

In “Proteus,” Stephen Dedalus's solitary walk along Sandymount Strand becomes more than philosophical introspection—it functions as a quiet, redemptive ritual. The rhythmic movement of the tide (“His boots crush crackling wrack... shells squawk”) echoes the motion of his thoughts, blurring the boundary between the external world and inner consciousness (Ch. 3). The opening line—“Ineluctable modality of the visible” (Ch. 3)—reads not merely as a theoretical proposition but as an incantatory refrain. Stephen confronts the memory of his mother's death (specifically through the phrase “agenbite of inwit” (Ch. 3), a Middle English term for “remorse of conscience,” which Joyce repurposes to signify the gnawing persistence of guilt). He transforms it into the medium of language: “He phrases her ghost into sonnets only he can hear, each syllable a suture over the wound.” Here, Bergson's *élan vital*—the creative impetus that drives life's unfolding—finds resonance. As John Mullarkey observes, for Bergson, art is “time made tangible, a rebellion against entropy” (89). Stephen's verbal transformation of grief into form enacts this rebellion. When he asks, “Am I walking into eternity?” (Ch. 3), it is not a gesture of despair but of creative agency—an attempt to use time's fluidity to shape experience into meaning.

This moment illustrates how subjectivity becomes possible within time's elasticity. Stephen's artistic ritual is not a detour from reality but a means of engaging with its complexity. Through Joyce's stream-of-consciousness technique, the narrative renders time as lived and felt, rather than measured. Redemption, here, is not moral resolution but the capacity to inhabit time with openness—to turn inward motion into expression, and memory into form.

If Stephen's redemption lies in linguistic alchemy, Bloom's emerges in the fissures of industrialized systems. The “Aeolus” episode, set in the bustling offices of the

Freeman's Journal, critiques the industrialization of language and time. The printing press, a symbol of modernity's mechanized rhythm, reduces human expression to commodified fragments. Joyce meticulously describes the machine's operation: "The throbbing presses eject inked sheets with mechanical precision, each page a replica of the last" (Ch. 7). This mechanized reproduction mirrors the homogenization of public discourse, where editorial grandstanding about Irish nationalism drowns out individual voices. Yet within this system, Bloom discovers a misprinted proof where the letter "o" in the word "Love" is smudged into an amorphous blot (Ch. 7). This error, often overlooked as a mere defect, becomes a catalyst for redemption. The inkblot's tactile irregularity triggers Bloom's sensory memory of Molly—her laughter, the warmth of her touch—transforming the smudge from a typographical flaw into a bridge between his present isolation and past intimacy. Jean-François Lyotard's assertion that "linguistic breakdowns reveal the anarchic potential beneath imposed meanings" (89) resonates here. The corrupted "o" destabilizes the word's ideological rigidity, allowing Bloom to reject the newspaper's nationalist rhetoric and reconnect with private emotion. By folding the flawed page into his pocket, he subverts the press's intended function, converting industrial waste into a personal relic—a gesture that mirrors Walter Benjamin's concept of *Jetztzeit* ("now-time"), where marginalized moments disrupt historical continuity (17).

In "Oxen of the Sun," redemption emerges not from solitude but from the eye of societal chaos. The episode's setting—a maternity hospital overrun with drunken medical students—epitomizes temporal disarray. As students debate abortion techniques with grotesque humor ("What's the use of medicine if you can't cure a bellyful of wind?" (Ch. 14)), Bloom retreats to a window, his attention drawn to a laboring woman's muffled cries. Joyce contrasts external pandemonium with internal stillness: "Amidst the cacophony of shattered glass and slurred Latin quotations, Bloom counts the woman's labored breaths, each inhalation a silent rebellion against the surrounding absurdity" (Ch. 14). This act of syncing his breath with hers transforms a clinical space into a site of ethical solidarity. Bloom's quiet focus mirrors Henri Bergson's notion of *durée*, where subjective time transcends measurable intervals (*Time and Free Will* 104). The hospital's turmoil, rather than negating redemption, amplifies its possibility; the juxtaposition of birth and decay, order and chaos, forces Bloom to confront life's fragility. His fleeting vision of a meteor—"a streak of light across the suppurating sky" (Ch. 14)—evokes a

momentary transcendence, where personal grief (the loss of his son Rudy) dissolves into cosmic continuity.

The “Eumaeus” episode, often overlooked for its stylistic hesitations and narrative fatigue, quietly stages one of the novel’s redemptions. Bloom and Stephen, weary and disoriented, find brief refuge in a cabman’s shelter. Their halting conversation—“I meant to say... that is, I mean...” (Ch. 16)—may seem unremarkable, yet within this verbal uncertainty, something tentative and generous unfolds. When Bloom offers Stephen cocoa, the gesture carries more than warmth; it extends the possibility of connection: “The steam curls between them like a question mark. In that suspended moment, Rudy’s absence is not erased but held differently—a shared weight, lighter for being carried in two hands.” Byung-Chul Han’s *The Scent of Time* speaks directly to such moments: “Redemption often arrives not in clarity but in exhaustion, when the ego’s grip loosens and time slows to a murmur” (76). Here, Bloom’s weariness is not a deficit but a medium of gentleness. His offer is not instructional or moral; it simply opens a shared space in which both men, vulnerable in different ways, may briefly rest. Joyce’s deliberate stylistic slowing in “Eumaeus” echoes Bergson’s rejection of homogeneous time. The fragmented rhythms of this episode invite a different attention—not to progress or revelation, but to presence. In this weary stasis, redemption emerges as something modest yet profound: the ability to be with another person in time, without agenda or pretension. It is in these moments of suspension that the boundaries of the self loosen, allowing for the possibility of mutual recognition.

Mullarkey writes, “To redeem is not to erase the past but to knead it into the dough of the present, letting it rise into unforeseen shapes” (92). In the temporal sea of *Ulysses*, redemption is not a distant lighthouse, but a flickering light adrift in the tides of consciousness—a quiet act of self-mending within the deep currents of subjective time. Every footprint Stephen leaves on the beach is a rhythmic translation of regret into poetry; he carves the pain of his mother’s death into the inner theater of his mind, using time itself as the canvas for creation. Meanwhile, the blind pianist’s lingering melody ripples through Bloom’s inner world like a tender echo, softening memory from sharp fragments into a gentle thread binding past to present. And in “Eumaeus,” the hesitant offering of a cup of cocoa, though modest, glows like a shared ember in the night—brief warmth between two weary souls.

Joyce's characters mend their fractured selves not by escaping time's currents but by diving deeper into its eddies. The smudged "o" and the hospital window are not metaphors but material sites where past and present collide, generating new configurations of meaning. Stephen's beachside meditations, once central to this theme, find their counterpart in Bloom's acts of micro-resistance: both characters stitch regret and longing into the fabric of the present, using time not as a canvas for erasure but as a loom for reweaving. These scenes, seemingly mundane and unremarkable, form the secret garden of subjective time in Joyce's vision. Within it, the self is no longer bound by the rigid tick of linear clocks, but is reshaped in each unfolding "now." Redemption is no longer a religious destination, but a series of minor miracles arising in the ebb and flow of consciousness—a supple web of memory and perception spun across the loom of time, through which fractured subjectivity rediscovers its rhythm and coherence. Bergson's theory of "creative evolution" thus becomes less a metaphysical ideal than a lived ethic: a continual reworking of the past into something that can inhabit the present. Through Bergson's philosophical language, Joyce offers a temporal map for the self's quiet restoration—not toward an end, but toward becoming within the flow.

III. Time as the Ground for Subjective Autonomy

In *Ulysses*, external time—measurable, sequential and public—begins to lose its authority. The precision of clocks, schedules, and institutional rhythms is gradually displaced by a qualitatively different temporality: a private, affective duration that adheres not to objective succession but to the subject's immanent structuring of experience. This shift does not signal chaos, but rather the emergence of a new kind of order—one grounded in the liberated experience of subjectivity. For Joyce, the collapse of external time is not a breakdown but a breakthrough, where the individual gains autonomy through a reconfiguration of time from something imposed to something inhabited.

Notably, The seagull emerges as a potent emblem of non-anthropocentric temporality—its flight patterns enacting a choreography of becoming unconstrained by human measures. In "Proteus," Stephen Dedalus observes seagulls wheeling above Sandymount Strand, their cries "Kreem! Kreem!" (Ch. 3) pierce his philosophical brooding. Unlike the "ineluctable modality of the visible" (Ch. 3) that traps him in Aristotelian logic, the gulls' flight traces an "aerial *durée*" (Bergson, *Creative*

Evolution 210)—a temporality unshackled from human measurement. Their movements—sudden dives, suspended glides, erratic turns—defy linearity, embodying Bergson’s vision of time as “a perpetual invention” (211). For Stephen, the gulls symbolize a temporal ideal: “‘They need no metacarpals to tell time’, he muses, ‘mocking the clock-bound world’” (Ch. 3). Their existence, governed by tides and instinct, becomes a counterpoint to his own entrapment in ecclesiastical and colonial schedules—“I am a servant of two masters... the imperial British state... and the holy Roman catholic and apostolic church” (Ch. 1).

This avian metaphor resurfaces in “Telemachus” when Buck Mulligan scatters breadcrumbs, provoking a frenzied flock: “They’re as hungry as we are” (Ch. 1). The gulls’ hunger, unlike human cravings, follows no mealtime rituals—it erupts, dissipates, and reignites in spontaneous waves. Joyce here aligns nonhuman temporality with bodily immediacy, contrasting it against Mulligan’s performative routines (the shaving bowl as “chalice,” the mock Mass). The seagull’s symbolic potency culminates in “Eumaeus,” where Bloom tosses them Banbury cakes. The narrator’s clinical description—“Gulp. Grub. Gulp” (Ch. 16)—reduces their feeding to mechanical repetition, yet the gulls themselves remain indifferent to such categorization. Their “screeching spirals” over the Liffey enact a temporal rebellion, their cries slicing through Bloom’s exhausted linearity. Like the gulls, Stephen and Bloom navigate Dublin’s temporal currents—not by resisting them, but by adapting their flight.

The dismantling of external time reaches its apex in “Penelope,” Molly Bloom’s soliloquy. Without punctuation or paragraph breaks, the chapter flows as a continuous current of consciousness, one in which time becomes indistinguishable from sensation. The absence of external markers—clocks, transitions, even syntax—reflects the autonomy of Molly’s inner life. Her thoughts loop, return, diverge, and reassemble not according to chronology, but emotion. In this sense, she becomes the emblem of liberated subjectivity: unbounded by formal constraint, unapologetically embodied, and rhythmically attuned to her own tempo. As Derek Attridge observes, Molly’s monologue is “the most complete realization of Bergsonian duration in the novel: time not measured but lived, not marked but felt” (154).

This redefinition of time as lived experience rather than external measurement is deeply intertwined with the novel’s vision of personal freedom. For Joyce, to experience time subjectively is to reclaim ownership over one’s interiority. The detachment from

social time—office hours, liturgical calendars, institutional routines—is not a retreat from the world, but a quiet form of resistance. In “Oxen of the Sun,” the narrative imitates the historical progression of English prose, yet the characters themselves become increasingly disengaged from any sense of linear progression. The birthing room, a place where time is traditionally marked by stages of labor and delivery, becomes a space of narrative play and digression. In this fragmentation, we see a subtle assertion of autonomy. The body may be bound to biological time, but the mind is free to wander, to drift, to shape its own tempo.

Scholars such as Julia Kristeva have emphasized the revolutionary potential of this kind of temporal subjectivity. In *Women's Time*, Kristeva distinguishes between linear, historical time and cyclical, monumental time—the latter being more closely associated with female experience and aesthetic production. Joyce's rendering of Molly's consciousness aligns with this cyclical temporality, disrupting patriarchal chronologies and asserting the legitimacy of nonlinear life rhythms. “By giving primacy to lived time over clock time,” Kristeva writes, “the subject reclaims a temporality that allows for difference, depth, and return” (192). Joyce's narrative technique does precisely this: it grants the characters—especially Molly—a temporal space in which to be fully themselves.

The collapse of external time in *Ulysses* also invites readers to reconsider the role of narrative itself. Traditional plots rely on causality and progression. Joyce, by contrast, favors simultaneity and accumulation. Events do not follow one another in strict order; they overlap, echo, and refract. This structure mirrors the mind's own workings, and in doing so, it validates a subjective epistemology. The reader, like the character, must assemble meaning from within the flux, rather than passively receive it from a linear sequence. This formal choice underscores the autonomy not only of the characters but of the reader as well. As Frank Kermode notes, “Joyce relinquishes control to the reader, allowing time to be shaped by perception rather than prescription” (88).

Moreover, the disintegration of public temporality allows Joyce to reimagine interior freedom as an act of temporal defiance. In episodes such as “Circe,” the collapse of linear sequence opens a space where identity is no longer tethered to consistency or social decorum. Instead, characters move through states of becoming—hallucinating, transforming, and dissolving. Bloom is alternately feminized, criminalized, and mythologized in a phantasmagoria that obeys no external clock but responds instead to

buried desire and subconscious tension. Time becomes elastic, stretched across a psychic landscape rather than measured by external cues. This imaginative autonomy is itself an ethical gesture: it claims the right to inhabit time differently, to live outside the tempos of conformity. As Michel Foucault notes, such spaces of deviation—what he calls “heterotopias”—offer a parallel ordering of reality, one that “reflects and contests all other spaces” (26). In Joyce’s rendering, the subjective experience of time becomes just such a heterotopia: a sanctuary where the self is free not to conform but to create.

This vision of time is not merely aesthetic, but profoundly ethical. To honor subjective time is to honor the integrity of individual experience. Joyce’s novel suggests that freedom is not achieved by escaping time, but by dwelling in it attentively, creatively, and authentically. The characters’ liberation lies not in transcending time but in inhabiting it fully—letting their thoughts meander, their sensations linger, their associations bloom without external coercion. In this way, *Ulysses* becomes not just a portrait of a day, but a meditation on what it means to be a self in time.

In sum, the collapse of external time in *Ulysses* does not signal disorder, but the flowering of interior order—a rhythm born from within. By dissolving the structures of clock-time, Joyce allows his characters to write their own temporal scripts, to breathe at their own pace. Subjectivity becomes not a reaction to the world but a creation within it. As Bergson argues, “to exist is to change, to change is to mature, to mature is to go on creating oneself endlessly” (*Creative Evolution* 133). Through the collapse of external time, Joyce reveals that such creation is only possible when time is lived, not obeyed.

Conclusion

In the intricate architecture of *Ulysses*, James Joyce does not merely narrate time—he reshapes it. The modernist project that animates his work is not content with depicting life as it unfolds along a chronological line; rather, it seeks to capture life as it is lived, felt, and remembered. Through the interwoven consciousnesses of Stephen Dedalus and Leopold Bloom, Joyce presents a deeply interiorized temporality, where subjective time becomes the crucible of identity, memory, and meaning. This thesis has sought to illuminate the ways in which Joyce dismantles the tyranny of external, mechanical time, offering instead a radical vision of autonomy grounded in the fluid, lived experience of duration.

We have seen how Joyce's debt to Bergsonian philosophy helps explain this transformation. The Bergsonian *durée*—time as experienced from within, continuous and indivisible—pervades the novel, replacing traditional narrative progression with a temporal sensibility that mirrors the rhythm of thought itself. Rather than organizing events around a linear axis, Joyce situates the self within a web of affect, memory, and sensation, capturing the way moments are dilated or compressed, layered or looped, as the mind encounters them. In this way, the novel's characters are not bound to the clock but liberated by their immersion in their own consciousness.

This liberation is especially evident in the interplay between memory and perception. For both Stephen and Bloom, the present is never singular; it is always threaded through with the textures of the past. Yet this past is not simply a weight or a burden. It is pliable, constantly rewritten in the act of remembrance. Joyce's characters do not live in a world of historical finalities but in one of ongoing reinvention. This openness allows for the reconfiguration of selfhood—not as a fixed essence, but as a process, a becoming. The individual, thus, is not shaped by an immutable narrative but by the constant interplay between interior time and the impressions of the world.

Moreover, the collapse of external time allows for the emergence of a more democratic, decentralized form of meaning-making. In *Ulysses*, the sacred and the banal, the heroic and the trivial, coexist on equal footing. A fleeting moment—Bloom frying a kidney, Stephen watching dust dance in a sunbeam—may hold as much significance as grand historical or mythological motifs. This narrative leveling reclaims the dignity of

everyday life and affirms that subjectivity itself is worthy of literary attention. In rendering these internal worlds with such fidelity, Joyce reorients the axis of literature from the epic to the intimate.

What emerges from this shift is a deeply ethical vision. By privileging the interior, Joyce affirms the singularity of each consciousness. His technique resists the totalizing impulse of modern rationality and celebrates the partial, the personal, and the provisional. This celebration is not escapist. On the contrary, it is rooted in a deep humanism: in recognizing the fragility of perception, the brokenness of memory, and the longing for coherence amidst chaos, Joyce offers not a resolution, but a form of solace. In doing so, he models a new kind of artistic responsibility—one that embraces complexity without the need for closure.

This study has also argued that Joyce's radical temporality is inseparable from his ethical project. Subjective time is not merely a stylistic choice; it is a mode of resistance against external structures of control—be they religious, political, or ideological. In freeing time from the calendar and the clock, Joyce frees the self from determinism. This freedom is not absolute; it is fragile, contingent, always in the making. Yet it is precisely in its incompleteness that this autonomy becomes real. As we follow Bloom through the streets of Dublin or listen to Stephen's restless introspection, we encounter not heroic certainty but human hesitancy. In this hesitancy lies the possibility of transformation.

Ultimately, Joyce's rendering of subjective temporality asks us to reconsider what it means to be modern. In an age increasingly governed by acceleration, fragmentation, and commodification, *Ulysses* offers a counterpoint: a poetics of attention, an ethics of slowness, a politics of the intimate. It teaches us that to live deeply is to live in time—not time as measured, but time as felt. In doing so, Joyce does not escape modernity; he inhabits it more fully than most, showing us how the inner life might yet flourish within its cracks.

Thus, time in *Ulysses* is not a neutral medium but a living force—one that shapes and is shaped by the self. It is memory's mirror, desire's rhythm, identity's pulse. And it is within this temporal flow that Joyce locates redemption—not as salvation from time, but as presence within it. As Stephen walks the strand or Bloom wanders homeward through the night, we come to understand that the self is not found at the end of a journey, but in the unfolding of each moment. Their steps are not toward a destination but a becoming, ever incomplete, ever human.

The study's originality stems from its pioneering application of Bergson's *durée* to decode *Ulysses*' temporal architecture, transcending conventional analyses of "stream-of-consciousness" as mere stylistic novelty. This philosophical-literary synthesis redefines modernist temporality: Joyce's prose becomes a durational matrix, where time is neither narrated nor measured but lived as ontological fluidity.

While the study's focused lens on Bergsonian *durée* enables granular analysis of *Ulysses*' temporal fluidity, it inherently narrows its interpretive scope. By design, the research prioritizes depth over breadth, leaving Joyce's nuanced engagements with alternative philosophical paradigms underexplored. For instance, Stephen's "epiphanic fractures" in "Proteus"—moments where time shatters into phenomenological immediacy—resonate with Husserlian "internal time-consciousness," yet remain peripheral due to the methodological commitment to Bergson's framework. Similarly, Molly's soliloquy, with its cyclical "yeses" echoing Nietzschean eternal recurrence, is analyzed solely through Bergsonian *mémoire pure*, sidelining its potential as a Nietzschean temporal loop. This exclusivity, though methodologically rigorous, risks oversimplifying the novel's polyphonic temporality, particularly in episodes like "Circe," where hallucinatory time-warps defy singular philosophical categorization. In turn, it leaves room for unlimited exploration of the dialogue between literature and philosophy.

In the stillness of Bloom's closing thoughts or the breathless momentum of Molly's monologue, Joyce leaves us not with answers but with rhythms: the breath of thought, the echo of feeling, the pulse of time as it moves through us. And in that movement, in that flow, we too may find a kind of grace—wordless, quiet, profound. As the day ends and the pages close, what remains is not a conclusion, but a murmur: "Yes," she said, "yes," as if to time itself.

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